

INBRIEF



Mental health wellness centre for GCC workers opened

The Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC) on Wednesday opened a mental health wellness centre, Mind Mantra, at Ripon Buildings for its employees, in association with CREDAI Foundation, Chennai, and Dhruvi Trust. GCC Commissioner G.S. Sameeran inaugurated the centre that aims to raise mental health awareness among employees and help them manage stress and build emotional resilience. Employees can register through the helpline or in-person on Mondays, Wednesdays, and Fridays, and receive counselling from psychologists and counsellors on Tuesdays and Thursdays.

KKCTH performs keyhole brain surgery on teenager

Kanchi Kamakoti CHILDS Trust Hospital (KKCTH), Chennai, has performed a minimally invasive keyhole brain surgery on a teenager who had two large brain tuberculomas in two different compartments of the brain. According to a press release, the child had been on standard anti-tubercular treatment for three months under S. Balasubramanian, Senior Consultant Paediatrician. K. Santosh Mohan Rao, Paediatric Neurosurgeon, planned an individualised minimally invasive keyhole approach to treat both lesions. The procedure was supported by advanced technology recently made available at KKCTH. The hospital recently received Centre of Excellence in Paediatric Care certification under the leadership of Janani Sankar, Medical Director, and Sanjay Chandran, CEO, the release said.

Text & Context and Science

Weekday features on *The Hindu* epaper (epaper.thehindu.com) carry explainers, special articles and quizzes. In the latest issue (September 3, Thursday), the following articles are available:

- Constitutional faultlines in FCRA Bill newsth.live/FCRAbill
 - A first step towards a universal vaccine against pneumonia, meningitis: newsth.live/universalsalvaccine
- You can use your smartphone's inbuilt features to access these articles. If it's an Android phone, use Google Lens to read and tap the url to access an article. If it's an iPhone, use Live Text on camera to do the same.



Innovative learning: The remodelled zootorium employs the 'Play and Learn' concept to engage students. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Remodelled Zoo Interpretation Centre opened at Vandalur

B. Aravind Kumar
CHENNAI

Arignar Anna Zoological Park, Vandalur, has further strengthened its commitment to wildlife education and conservation awareness by opening a remodelled Zoo Interpretation Centre (Zootorium), exclusively for school groups. The upgraded facility combines innovative technology, interactive learning models, and creative interpretation techniques to provide a modern and engaging learning experience for the present generation of children, according to a press release. The Zootorium reception has been creatively designed on a Western Ghats theme. It features a range of advanced technology-based interactive interpretation models designed to make learning about wildlife more interesting, experiential, and child-friendly. Instead of conven-

tional display panels, students can explore concepts through interactive models and digital learning experiences. One of the key attractions is an interactive multiplication table with holographic technology to help students understand important ecological concepts such as the food chain, food web, prey and predator relationships, through an engaging learning approach. The centre also features an interactive zoo layout, with the locations of animals marked on the map. The facility includes two innovative selfie points. A unique interactive paw-mark feature enables children to step on animal paw marks, triggering information about the respective animal. Around 500 kg of discarded rubber tyres have been creatively reused to construct animal models at the centre.

From digital distraction to AI readiness, educators discuss ways of learning for children

An educator says digitisation has affected the brain in terms of the neurochemicals that process the information, and more than two hours of exposure to social media will affect the grey cells

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The *Hindu In School* Educators' Confluence 2026 brought together educators and academic leaders across the city on Wednesday to discuss ideas on 'The New School of Thought: Rethinking, Learning, Reimagining Leadership, Shaping a New Generation.' "The theme, New school of Thought, is about reimagining learning environments that balance technology and humanity, innovation with values, and academic excellence with holistic development," said P. Subramaniam, Regional Head, The Hindu Group. R.A. Babu Vijay, Assistant Vice President, Sales & Distribution, The Hindu Group, said: "This is not another discussion on the challenges facing education but an invitation to collectively create environments and rediscover focus through purpose."

Constant digitisation The first session, "The Digital Child: Are we losing attention, connection and curiosity?" saw Lakshmi Vijayakumar, Founder of SNEHA and Head of the Department of Psychiatry at VHS, discuss how constant digitisation is affecting children particularly those from lower-income countries, where children may have only a few avenues for recreation. "Digitisation has affected the brain in terms of the neurochemicals that process the information. When you have more than two hours of exposure to social me-



Lakshmi Vijayakumar, Founder of SNEHA, Sridhar Aranala, Chief Sales and Distribution Officer, The Hindu Group, and Ramya Venkataraman, Founder & CEO of the Centre for Teacher Accreditation, at *The Hindu In School* Educators' Confluence in the city on Wednesday. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

dia, your grey cells are affected," she said, adding how the parents today introduce gadgets into children's formative stages to keep them quiet, often during meals. This practice needs to change. She also touched upon behavioural addiction, deliberate emotionality, the side effects of social media including cyber bullying, and how many schools abroad are choosing to return to tools over tech after the constant digitisation. "We have found that when you use social media for more than two hours, for every one-hour increase in the use of social media, anxiety, depression and suicidal thoughts increase by 18% because it constantly makes you feel bad about yourself," added Dr. Vijayakumar. She also asked the parents to set aside gadget-free time every day, and how children should be allowed to feel boredom to stimulate their creativity. In the session on "The

Teacher of Tomorrow: Empowering Education in the Age of AI," Ramya Venkataraman, Founder & CEO of the Centre for Teacher Accreditation, visualised the teachers of tomorrow as professionals who see their own growth alongside their students'. Teacher competencies She spoke about educators understanding where they stand as professionals, assessing teacher competencies, training and tools, and using technology to provide personalised support. "If teaching is being done badly in a particular classroom and in this classroom, we also put some technology, nothing much is going to change except the classroom is going to become fancier," adds Ms. Venkataraman. "Therefore, it is important to first see the teacher as professional and then think about where technology including Artificial Intelligence can play a role," she

added. The session also included a discussion on the human capabilities such as problem solving, design thinking, communication, interpersonal skills, and judgment which will continue to matter for students as they grow up in a world dominated by AI. AI readiness for a school or teacher, she said, means the ability to build these human capabilities while using AI responsibly to improve learning and work. "The more use of AI does not correspond to higher readiness of AI. What matters is AI leverage along with digital safety and safeguards. AI readiness for teachers also includes understanding AI and its potential impact, adaptability and continuous learning, and building future ready human capabilities for students," added Ms. Venkataraman.



Participants at *The Hindu In School* Educators' Confluence in the city on Wednesday. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

Digital health, literacy should be taught in schools: educators

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Digital health and digital literacy should be an important part of school curriculum while emphasis should be laid on organising classes on digital hygiene at least once a month, experts at an Educators' Conclave said here on Wednesday. The confluence, titled "The New School of Thought: Rethinking Learning, Reimagining Leadership, Shaping a New Generation", was organised by *The Hindu In School* in strategic partnership with Blue Scorp where the discussion flowed from the role of teachers and parents in shaping digital habits and reading patterns in the children, to the challenge faced by educators with emerging technologies like Artificial Intelligence.

Taking questions from educators during an open session, Lakshmi Vijayakumar, Founder, SNEHA and Head, Department of Psychiatry, VHS, said children till the age of seven should be kept away from digital exposure and from 12 years onwards, there could be guided exposure with definitive controls. "Teachers and parents will have to be on the same page on this," she emphasised.

"Technology itself is not bad, but what it replaces could be. If it replaces family time, interaction with friends, and playtime, then it would do more harm to the child," she added. Ramya Venkataraman, Founder and CEO, Centre for Teacher Accreditation, said with the advent of AI and with growing investments, it is a reality everyone will have to face at some time. It was important to draw boundaries and leverage the technology which will require understanding of the next level of detail. "You will have to be clear on where the leverage of technology is. A teacher who is able to do this will remain relevant," she observed. Sridhar Aranala, Chief Sales and Distribution Officer, The Hindu Group, said that the decline of reading habits among children and their shrinking attention spans provide a new challenge before the newspaper industry. "What is given to them (the students) to catch their attention is important. If you provide something compelling, it may well catch their attention," he pointed out, stating that publications of The Hindu Group - *In School* and *Young World* - have been attempting to design their content keeping these aspects in mind. M. Thiagarajan, General Manager - Sales and Distribution, The Hindu Group, proposed a vote of thanks.

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I, Vasantha Muthu (DOB: 24.07.1964). No. 1/560, 9th Street, Balaganesan Nagar, Attanhangal, Padiyanallur, Sholavaram, Chennai - 600067, shall henceforth be known as Vasantha Kuppasamy - Vasantha. K

I, A. Mohamed Wasim, S/o Mohamed Ali, D.O.B. 05/07/1991, residing at No. 7/49, Bajajani, Koil Street, Movilavakkam, Chennai-116, shall henceforth be known as Mohammed Wasim A. Affidavit dated 02/09/2026

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FORM NO. INC-26
[Pursuant to Rule 30 of Companies (Incorporation) Rules 2014]
Advertisement to be published in Newspaper for the change in Registered Office of the Company from one state to another

Before the Regional Director Southern Region Bench, Chennai
In the matter of sub-section 4 of section 13 of the Companies Act 2013 and clause (a) of sub-section (5) of Rule 30 of the Companies (Incorporation) Rules 2014
AND
In the matter of CHOICE INFOWAY PRIVATE LIMITED having its Registered Office at 302, Akshaya Shanthi, Third Floor 27/44, Anna Salai, Mount Road, Triplicane Village, Chennai, Tamil Nadu-600002

Notice is hereby given to General Public that the company proposes to make the application to the Central Government under section 13 of the Companies Act 2013, seeking confirmation of alteration of Memorandum of Companies of the company in term of special resolution passed at Extra ordinary General Meeting held on Friday, 17th day of July, 2026 to enable the company to change its Registered Office from "State of Tamil Nadu" to "State of Kerala".

Any person whose interest is likely to be affected by the proposed change, may deliver either on MCA portal (www.mca.gov.in) by filling investor complaint form or cause to be delivered or send by registered post of his/her objections supported by an affidavit stating the nature of his/her interest and ground of opposition to the Regional Director at the Address 5th Floor, Shastri Bhavan, 26 Haddows Road, Chennai-600006, Tamil Nadu, within 14 Days of date of publication of this notice with a copy to the applicant company at its registered office at the address mentioned below.

ADDRESS OF REGISTERED OFFICE: 302, Akshaya Shanthi, Third Floor 27/44, Anna Salai, Mount Road, Triplicane Village, Chennai, Tamil Nadu-600002
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Thomas Jose
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Sd/-
Thomas Jose
Whole-time Director
DIN: 063366431
Date: 31.08.2026

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ADDRESS OF REGISTERED OFFICE: 302, Akshaya Shanthi, Third Floor 27/44, Anna Salai, Mount Road, Triplicane Village, Chennai, Tamil Nadu-600002
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Director
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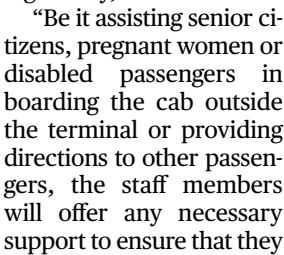
(As told to Athira Elssa Johnson)

Chennai has also been deeply welcoming to me as a doctor. I have always valued the trust patients and

dance in Madras on December 26, 1989. This photo and more are on display at *The Hindu* Made of Chennai Archival Photo Exhibit as part of Madras Month celebrations. The exhibition will be on at *The Hindu* office till September 14 and is open to the public from 10 a.m. to 6.30 p.m. on all days, except Sundays.

To visit, register for free at <https://madeofchennai.thehindu.com/>

The staff members, wearing uniforms with badges indicating that they are there to assist the passengers, will be present outside the T1 and T4 Dom-



Devaraj Damodaram, a resident of Chromepet, recollected the hassle he had faced when he landed at the Chennai airport some months ago. "When I exited the domestic terminal, I felt lost and couldn't find my way out. The signage

City hospital performs robotic surgery to remove tumour from thyroid gland

Doctors at Kauvery Hospital, Vadapalani, performed a robotic surgery to remove a cancerous tumour from the thyroid gland of a

The woman had noticed a swelling in her neck, which gradually increased in size. Investigations, along with a biopsy, confirmed the presence of a

A team led by Sathish Kumar Anandan, senior

consultant, surgical oncology and robotic surgeon, performed a minimally invasive robotic total thyroidectomy with resection of the involved strap muscle, and removed the tumour while preserving her voice.

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Chandra family



Orthodoxy redux

Religion is oft used as a tool to suppress women in the public sphere

Veteran Islamic cleric Kanthapuram A.P. Aboobacker Musliar’s directive to restrict Muslim women’s participation in public celebrations has unsettled Keralam because it strikes at a fundamental question: women’s right to participate in public life. This is not merely a quarrel over how Muslims should mark Prophet Muhammad’s 1,501st birth anniversary. It is a test of how far religious authority can intrude into the lives of women in a State that takes pride in its progressive social history. Kanthapuram says he is merely reminding followers of established religious norms. His supporters argue Milad celebrations have moved beyond mosques and madrasas into large public events, and that scholars have a duty to caution against such departures. That argument holds no weight. Communities have the right to preserve traditions and regulate religious practices, but they have to conform to the values enshrined in the Constitution. When women are told to remain at home because their presence could cause “chaos”, the issue is no longer about religious observance; it is at variance with constitutional equality and Keralam’s long struggle to expand the space in public life for women disadvantaged by social customs and religious traditions.

The Muslim community is not a monolith. It contains both orthodox and progressive currents. More Muslim women are breaking barriers in education, employment, politics and public life, but that progress is encountering a counter-current of renewed orthodoxy and social control. The CPI(M), Keralam’s main Opposition party and a decades-old ally of the Kanthapuram-led faction of Samastha Kerala Jamiyyathul Ulama, a body of Sunni scholars, has responded sharply. The Congress, which leads the ruling coalition, was largely guarded until Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan rubbished the decree as antediluvian. The Indian Union Muslim League’s silence is harder to defend. A party with an active women’s forum and a woman legislator for the first time in the State Assembly cannot equivocate when women’s right to public participation is open to challenge. Its caution may reflect political pressure over Waqf, *Vande Mataram* and PM-SHRI, or an attempt to improve ties with the Kanthapuram faction amid strained relations with the rival Samastha faction. Whatever the political calculation, silence carries a cost. Religious freedom does not confer on religious authorities the right to regulate women’s freedom of movement, association and degree of participation in society. During Onam, social media were awash with videos of young Muslim girls celebrating the harvest festival. Kanthapuram’s remarks drew criticism from a section of Muslim women on social media. Keralam cannot claim to be progressive while making exceptions for orthodoxy.

Many layers

Farmers need more storage facilities and better distribution networks

Since the 1960s, India has developed a balancing-act habit: between keeping food prices affordably low for consumers and assuring farmers of remunerative prices, with the state’s interventions focused on managing this volatility in the short term. This is also why the government banned onion exports from December 2023 to May 2024, then imposed a \$550/tonne minimum export price and a 40% export duty, reduced the duty to 20% in September 2024, and finally abolished it in April 2025. But erratic weather together with the lack of long-term relief has rendered the act increasingly awkward. From farmers’ point of view, the government often changes its mind after they have made important production-related decisions based on the expected price. On the other hand, during the bounteous *rabi* harvest, onion farmers in Maharashtra, the country’s principal supplier, had argued that the Centre’s procurement price of ₹12.35/kg would not cover the costs of cultivation. The Centre subsequently raised the price to up to ₹26.45/kg, but many farmers – including some who had had to sell at ₹1/kg earlier because of low quality and lack of storage, among other factors – were unable to capture the higher value, exposing the limits of intervening after prices have already collapsed and not reaching all farmers or grades of produce.

While the government has alluded to some price manipulation, the dominant issue remains that it keeps reacting instead of taking proactive measures, including improving storage options, maintaining a less erratic trade policy, moving stock more efficiently between regions, and protecting farmers against price shocks. The abnormal rainfall at the time of harvest and a 5%-7% drop in the *kharif* crop in Maharashtra, together with the well-known challenges associated with storing onions and maintaining large buffers, are simply among the pressures that highlighted the flaw this year. Further, Tamil Nadu’s targeted subsidy, to buy 1,000 tonnes of onions to distribute 1 kg per ration card at ₹35, will impose pressures on the Centre to maintain a steady supply. The move is commendably designed to discourage hoarding while allowing private retail prices to cool down. However, the State must also guard against the pitfalls of distributing onions through a dry-grain PDS network – its economic case could collapse if post-harvest losses, to which onion is more susceptible than, say, wheat or rice, exceed 10%-15% – and if the need arises to persist with the subsidy. Finally, if other States also adopt similar measures, the Central buffer could be quickly exhausted, more so given this year’s high storage losses of around 30%.

On August 25, 2026, in Beijing, National Security Adviser Ajit Doval and China’s Foreign Minister Wang Yi held the 25th round of talks between the Special Representatives (SRs) on the India-China boundary question. That evening’s readouts from both sides were anodyne and notably avoided a phrase that has dominated this discussion for a year: early harvest. A day later, the two sides released an “Eight Points of Outcomes and Consensus”. Point 3 restored and enhanced the phrase: the Expert Group on Boundary Delimitation and the Working Group on Border Management, set up under the Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination (WMCC) a year ago, would “respectively advance discussions on an Early and Substantial Harvest of boundary delimitation and Border Management”. Their first task, it adds, is to agree on their own terms of reference, one year after they were constituted, suggesting that whatever is being contemplated remains at an early stage

An uncertain Early Harvest

The phrase “Early and Substantial Harvest” is significant because it is India’s own coinage. When Beijing first proposed settling the Sikkim Sector alone, India’s considered response, around 2019, was a counter-proposal on an “Early and Substantial Harvest” covering the Sikkim Sector together with the entire Middle Sector, with the boundary delineated along the watershed. China rejected the proposal. In subsequent discussions on an “Early Harvest,” China reportedly agreed only to include the Sikkim Sector and some undisputed areas of the Middle Sector – a proposal that was unacceptable to India.

The exact Indian formulation has now resurfaced in a joint document. This could mean that Beijing has accepted India’s terms – which this writer doubts – as that would involve China giving up its claim to approximately 2,450 square kilometres of territory in the Middle Sector, all south of the watershed boundary (Barahoti, Giu-Kaurik, Nilang-Jadhang, Sangcha Malla, and Lapthal). It could equally mean something the Indian side had rejected earlier: an “agreement with holes”, a settlement nominally covering both sectors but confined to stretches where the claims already coincide, leaving the trijunctions and contested pockets of the Middle Sector undefined.

If that is the case, we will have the same asymmetric outcome as with a Sikkim-only settlement – India conceding ground where its position is strong, without any progress in the Eastern and Western Sectors, where China maintains its hardline position, “dong tiao xi rang”, meaning “meaningful adjustments by India in the East and corresponding concessions by China in the West”. It would also jettison a key provision (Article III) of the 2005 Agreement on



Ashok K. Kantha

Former Ambassador of India to China; Subhas Chandra Bose Chair Professor of International Relations at Chanakya University, Bengaluru, and the lead Indian negotiator for the Agreement on Political Parameters and Guiding Principles for Boundary Settlement (2005)

India-China boundary talks suggest movement, but hard questions remain over strategic costs and concessions

Political Parameters and Guiding Principles for the Settlement of the India-China Boundary, which calls for a “package settlement ...covering all sectors of the India-China boundary”, opting instead to bank the easy gains immediately while leaving the hard issues open on China’s terms. The package clause exists precisely because the boundary’s four sectors are strategically interlinked, requiring cross-sector give and take.

No open-and-shut case

The Sikkim Sector is also not the open-and-shut case that some suggest. The two sides agree that the Anglo-Chinese Convention of 1890 is the “basis of the alignment” of the boundary in this sector. However, Article I of the Convention contains two stipulations that are mutually contradictory. Its first sentence makes the watershed crest the boundary, while its second names Mount Gipmochi as the starting point on the Bhutan frontier. Yet, British Indian maps of 1907 and 1913 placed the trijunction not at Gipmochi but roughly 6.5 kilometres to its north, on the true watershed crest. India and Bhutan read the watershed principle as controlling and place the trijunction at Batang La; China seizes on the literal reference to Gipmochi to push the trijunction southwards, onto the Jampheri Ridge. A Sikkim delimitation built on the 1890 text, unless it repudiates Gipmochi, would be read by Beijing as conceding the southern trijunction.

Even a trijunction-reserved settlement would strip India of the standing to counsel Bhutan against a bilateral deal, having itself settled out of turn nearby. China’s “package proposal” to Bhutan – relinquishing roughly 495 sq km of claims in the north in exchange for Bhutan ceding about 269 sq km in the northwest, including the Doklam Plateau – would gain fresh momentum, deepening China’s presence in the Chumbi Valley and opening a path to the Jampheri Ridge, from which the entire Siliguri Corridor, India’s sole overland link to its northeastern States, would come under direct observation. This is not hypothetical: since the 2017 Doklam standoff, China has spent years building roads, villages, and military facilities across western Bhutan, gaining de facto control over Doklam.

A genuine “Early and Substantial Harvest” requires three things. First, delineation must proceed on the highest-watershed principle across the entire stretch in both sectors, rather than selectively along segments where the two positions already converge, which would serve no purpose for India. Second, trijunction points, at Batang La and any comparable third-country-adjacent points in the Middle Sector, must be explicitly excluded from the Expert Group’s mandate and settled only in consultation with the country concerned, as stipulated in the 2012 Common Understanding between the two SRs. However, unless the highest-watershed principle is accepted, silence

Reducing India’s exposure to U.S. tariff risks



Himanshu Jaiswal

Consultant at the Centre for Social and Economic Progress, New Delhi

The Lindsey O. Graham Act puts India under pressure, but export diversification and domestic reforms can cushion shocks

the strategy has helped secure supplies, it carries diplomatic costs, particularly in managing ties with the United States, which seeks to strongly discourage these imports. The U.S. Russia Sanctions Act reflects this pressure.

On July 24, before the bill’s introduction, the U.S. imposed forced-labour tariffs on 60 countries, including India, under Section 301 of the Trade Act of 1974, imposing an additional 10% tariff, a replacement of the expired 10% duty under Section 122, on India. If the Russia Sanctions Act becomes law, India’s cumulative tariff could reach 110%, making it one of the most heavily tariffed countries. Such high tariffs could affect India’s price competitiveness in the U.S., a major export market, leading to economic losses. China’s cumulative tariff could reach 112.5%, as both countries are major importers of Russian crude.

Trade simulations and results

To analyse the trade dynamics and possible way forward for India, two global trade simulations were conducted using the GTAP dataset and model, a global general equilibrium model that captures global linkages and country-level shocks. The first (sanction scenario) models a 110% U.S. tariff on India, with other countries facing forced-labour tariffs and China facing 112.5%. The second (diversification scenario) applies the same tariffs while India pursues export diversification, proxied by a full India-European Union free trade agreement (FTA).

The simulation results suggest that the proposed U.S. sanctions could have adverse consequences for the Indian economy. Under the sanction scenario, India’s welfare declines by nearly \$47 billion, while GDP, output, domestic demand, exports, and imports all contract. Aggregate exports fall by 5.1% and imports by 5.2%, reflecting disrupted trade flows and weaker

on the trijunction will, on the ground, be filled in Beijing’s favour in Bhutan. Third, the terms of reference for the Expert Group must extend India’s 2019 proposal in good faith, rather than dilute it beyond recognition.

Several questions about these negotiations remain unanswered. The Chinese readout of August 25 reiterates a commitment to a “package” settlement, but how will that commitment be reconciled with a piecemeal approach to settlement? How is the setting up of an Expert Group on Delimitation consistent with the instructions given to the SRs in Article X of the 2005 Agreement, which require them to “continue consultations in an earnest manner with the objective of arriving at an agreed framework for a boundary settlement, which will provide the basis for the delineation and demarcation of the India-China boundary to be subsequently undertaken by civil and military officials and surveyors of the two sides”? There is no agreed framework yet, but it is proposed to commence the process of “delimitation”, a term that the Chinese use interchangeably with “demarcation”. Indeed, the 2005 Agreement does not use the term “delimitation” at all. Will the SRs earnestly pursue negotiations on the “agreed framework”, or will they, in effect, leave it in abeyance while officials grapple with a partial delimitation exercise without such a framework? The other elements of the Eight Points – additional meeting points and hotlines for the General Level Mechanisms in the Eastern and Middle Sectors, continued pilgrimage and border trade, and a September meeting on trans-border rivers – are useful, incremental confidence-building measures. But they belong to a different track from boundary settlement and should not be conflated in public discussion.

The Eight Points are silent on the Medog County project on the Yarlung Tsangpo River, while referring to both sides agreeing to “maintain communication on (trans-border river) issues, including hydrological data sharing and renewal of the relevant MoUs”, without reporting any progress. The September meeting should convey India’s concerns about the project – the world’s largest hydropower plant – being built close to the border in the Eastern Sector, in a highly earthquake-prone zone, a risk underscored by the flash floods in Nepal on August 26.

Avoid optics

Two points bear reiteration. First, the 2005 agreement – the only substantive outcome of 23 years of SR talks – must not be diluted; China has sought to reinterpret and undermine it since its conclusion. Second, Indian negotiators must guard against the temptation to project contrived progress. Diplomacy that trades long-term strategic interests for short-term optics is self-defeating.

The U.S. Senate recently passed the Lindsey O. Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act of 2026, imposing sanctions and authorising additional tariffs and other restrictions related to Russia. Most concerning is a provision authorising tariffs of up to 100% on countries among the five largest importers of Russian crude oil or natural gas if they knowingly make new purchases after enactment. Though it still awaits House approval, enactment could have serious implications for India’s economic interests.

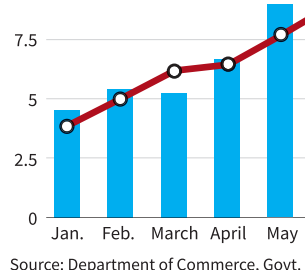
The Russian oil dilemma

India has diversified its energy supplies in recent years to reduce its crude import bill and gain strategic advantage amid global uncertainty, driving a sharp rise in Russian crude imports. Before the Russia-Ukraine conflict, Russian crude accounted for just 2% of India’s imports; it is now roughly half.

In 2026 alone, imports nearly doubled from 4.54 MMT in January to 8.96 MMT in May. While

India’s crude import from Russia

Quantity (MMT)
Share in total crude imports (%)



Source: Department of Commerce, Govt. of India

Impact of tariffs and export diversification

	Sanction scenario	Diversification scenario
Welfare (\$ billion)	-46.6	26.3
Change in GDP (%)	-0.02	0.01
Sectoral output (%)	-1.9	1.2
Domestic demand (%)	-1.8	1
Aggregate export (%)	-5.1	3.1
Aggregate import (%)	-5.2	2.6

Source: Writer’s analysis using GTAP

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

The north-south lens

The main article (Editorial page, September 2) risks turning a complex federal question into a simplistic north-versus-south narrative. India’s political influence has never been determined by geography alone; it reflects population, electoral mandates, governance, economic contribution and the ability of States to build national

coalitions. The southern States continue to exercise considerable political, economic and institutional influence, while several leaders from the region have shaped national policy. Portraying elected southern governments as “suppliant” or “submissive” is subjective and needlessly polarising. Delimitation deserves rigorous constitutional

debate, but framing it primarily as northern domination may deepen regional divisions rather than strengthen India’s federal compact.

Venkat Parthasarathy, Hyderabad

Austerity call

The call to citizens of the country to avoid unnecessary foreign travel and destination weddings

abroad to conserve foreign exchange would carry greater weight if accompanied by restraint from those at the top. Overseas travel by national leaders may often be necessary in the public interest, but when citizens are asked to limit their foreign expenditure, similar prudence from those in positions of authority would strengthen the message.

Leadership is not only about asking citizens to sacrifice, but also about setting an example.

Tharcus S. Fernando, Chennai

Football’s great artist

Legend Lionel Messi’s retirement from international football marks the end of one of modern sport’s most extraordinary chapters. For two decades,

he transformed football into an art form, carrying Argentina’s expectations through years of heartbreak and criticism. He leaves the international stage not only as a statistical giant, but also as a symbol of humility, grace and vision.

R. Sivakumar, Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

The views expressed are personal

River-linking is not the solution

The Union Minister for Home Affairs Amit Shah's speech at the Southern Zonal Council's meeting last month in Mamallapuram has provided a few takeaways on the contentious issue of water sharing. His emphasis on the need for an early resolution of water-related issues in the southern region appears well meaning but it is easier said than done. He had also talked about linking major rivers from the Brahmaputra to the Godavari and the Cauvery, an option that, according to Mr. Shah, can ensure that India faces no water shortage for 100 years.

However, water issues are not that easy to solve. This is evident from the Centre's response to Tamil Nadu's demand for the constitution of a tribunal to adjudicate the Pennaiyar river water dispute. Aggrieved over the "violation" of the 1892 inter-State agreement by Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, in November 2019, requested the Centre to establish a tribunal. It had also moved the Supreme Court with the same demand. Since then, two negotiation committees have been formed and 11 meetings held. Eventually, the top court, this February, directed the Centre to form the tribunal within a month and, later, extended the deadline by six months.

Still, the adjudicatory body is yet to be put in place. Meanwhile, the Centre asked the court whether the Pennaiyar dispute could be referred to the Mahadayi Water Dispute Tribunal instead of constituting a new tribunal. This suggestion defies logic as there is nothing in common between the two



T. Ramakrishnan

disputes. Moreover, the Interstate River Water Disputes Act, 1956 does not permit it. This suggestion in the Pennaiyar case gives the impression that the Centre is not keen on expeditiously implementing a judicial verdict in an inter-State river dispute. To cite one more example, the Central government has not yet replied to Tamil Nadu's demand, in March this year, to constitute a tribunal on the Mekedatu dam project proposed by Karnataka.

A complex problem
Given this background, one need not delve much into the complications that would entail by the inter-linking of rivers. Proponents of river linking, including Tamil Nadu, have been saying that the idea is not to disturb the natural flow of any river but to divert a portion of the surplus water. Many experts are not convinced about this argument as they are worried that once the linking is allowed, regions that benefit may become vociferous in demanding water even in times of distress, eventually depriving original beneficiaries of their quota. This is apart from the concerns over the possible adverse consequences on ecology. In fact, Keralam has been stoutly opposing the Pamba-Achankovil-Vaippar link proposal, which, if implemented, the State says, will affect the Vembanad wetland system, where the Pamba and Achankovil rivers drain. However, the National Water Development Agency says that it has accounted for improving the flow of rivers in lean periods.

In the last 130-odd years, the country has seen only a handful of inter-basin transfer projects, most of which are in south India

In the last 130-odd years, the country has seen only a handful of inter-basin transfer projects, most of which are in south India

Mullaperiyar dam, the Parambikulam-Aliyar project, the Krishna Water Supply Project, and the Indira Gandhi Canal Project are regarded as successful examples of inter-basin transfer of river waters. After the Bharatiya Janata Party's return to power in 2014, the Union government formed a Special Committee for Interlinking of Rivers, which has held over two dozen meetings since then. Needless to say, there has not been much headway.

However, in 2024, Prime Minister Narendra Modi laid the foundation stone for the ₹44,000 crore Ken-Betwa Link Project. This has now led to agitations by the tribal populations in Chhatarpur.

What the governments, both at the Centre and in States, and civil society should focus on is demand side management, instead of perpetually looking for supply side interventions. With land becoming scarcely available and resistance growing among people when it comes to land acquisition, the days of implementing mega irrigation projects are almost over. The priority has to be towards conserving what is available and using it judiciously. A massive programme of sensitising and incentivising farmers on the optimal use of water has to be launched. Indiscriminate extraction of groundwater, facilitated by schemes of free electricity for agriculture in many States, is paving the way for ecological disaster and has to be curbed immediately. Unless water conservation becomes the mantra of all the stakeholders and is practised genuinely, disputes will be the norm.

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Mental health must anchor public health

India stands at a defining moment in its journey towards the vision of Viksit Bharat 2047. Under the Healthcare for All pillar, the government has rightly prioritised strengthening Ayushman Bharat, expanding primary healthcare, reducing out-of-pocket expenditure, and promoting preventive care. Yet there is one element that cuts across all these ambitions and determines their success: mental health.

Mental health is not a niche concern. It influences educational attainment, workforce participation, social cohesion, and physical health outcomes. A healthier and more productive India cannot be built without placing mental well-being at the centre of public health.

Major implications
The scale of the challenge is substantial. Mental illness affects one in seven Indians, with nearly 200 million people living with a diagnosable mental health condition. The contribution of mental disorders to India's total disease burden has doubled over the past three decades. Yet the national treatment gap remains 84.5%, meaning that more than four out of five people who need care do not receive it. The reasons are well known. India has only 0.3 psychiatrists per 1,00,000 population, alongside significant shortages in clinical psychologists, psychiatric social workers, and psychiatric nurses. These shortages are the result of decades during which mental health received insufficient attention, both in India and globally.

Mental disorders significantly increase the risk



Indu Bhushan

Founding CEO of India's National Health Authority and Ayushman Bharat



Anisha Padukone

CEO of The Live Love Laugh Foundation

of chronic diseases, while chronic diseases in turn increase the risk of mental illness. More than 60% of people attending primary care facilities have a diagnosable mental disorder. Rates of anxiety and depression are substantially higher among people living with diabetes, hypertension, tuberculosis, and HIV/AIDS. Ignoring mental health, therefore, undermines efforts to control non-communicable diseases and reduce healthcare expenditure.

The economic implications are equally compelling. A 2025 modelling study by researchers from PGIMER and NIMHANS estimated that integrating universal depression screening into India's primary healthcare system could generate net savings of ₹291 billion to ₹482 billion annually, equivalent to as much as 0.32% of GDP. Mental health is not a social welfare issue alone – it is also a human capital investment and an economic growth strategy.

The encouraging news is that India has already built many of the foundations required for transformation. More than 1.73 lakh sub-centres and primary health centres have been converted into Ayushman Bharat Arogya Mandirs, with mental healthcare included among the essential service packages. The District Mental Health Programme now covers more than 90% of districts. Tele-MANAS, launched in 2022, has expanded across all States and Union Territories.

Three main priorities
The task now is not to start from scratch. It is to build on this foundation at scale. First, one must empower

If India is to become a truly developed nation by 2047, mental health must move from the margins of public policy to its centre

frontline health workers to become the backbone of community mental healthcare. India's one million ASHA workers represent the world's largest community health workforce. Evidence from Madhya Pradesh and other States demonstrates that, with appropriate training and supervision, ASHAs can successfully identify, support, and refer individuals with common mental disorders. Expanding this model through validated screening tools, digital learning platforms, and performance-linked incentives could expand access to care.

Second, India must invest more systematically in community-based care. Models such as Zimbabwe's Friendship Bench, Atmiyata in India, and programmes implemented by The Live Love Laugh Foundation demonstrate that trained community workers can bridge the gap between awareness and treatment, particularly in rural and underserved populations. These approaches improve access and reduce costs, and deserve wider adoption and funding. Third, the country must fully realise the promise of financial protection. Extending outpatient mental health benefits under the Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana and strengthening the implementation of insurance parity as per the Mental Healthcare Act, 2017, would make mental healthcare affordable for millions who currently go without care.

If India is to become a truly developed nation by 2047, mental health must move from the margins of public policy to its centre.

Decoding Russia's reliance on Indian petroleum products

Ukraine's recent relentless attacks on Russia's oil refineries has led the country to rely on India for petroleum imports

DATA POINT

Nitika Francis

Recent Ukrainian attacks on Russia's oil refineries has resulted in the latter importing refined petroleum products from India in significant quantities for the first time, at least since the Russia-Ukraine war started in February 2022.

As per multiple media reports, including one by the *Press Trust of India*, Indian refiners sent about one million barrels over the last two months, alongside Turkey and Morocco. Russia's import of petroleum products from India has remained negligible in the past, accounting for less than one per cent of India's petroleum exports. The bulk of exports went to countries like the Netherlands, Australia and the UAE (**Chart 1**).

Though the Indian government's export and import-related data for the last two months is yet to be released, reports have confirmed that the country's export of refined petroleum products to Russia has sharply increased in the last two months. This has tilted the huge imbalance that existed between the two countries in oil trade, albeit marginally. India continues to remain hugely dependent on Russia for crude.

One-fourth of India's petroleum imports since January 2022 were from Russia and this number remained high before U.S. President Donald Trump imposed additional tariffs on India in October 2025 for buying crude from Russia.

Though this resulted in India sharply cutting down its crude import from Russia, the imports resumed in full swing soon after. In fact, after the U.S. and Israel launched a war with Iran in February this year, the former did a U-turn in its stance and tacitly encouraged Russian crude supplies into the market to negate the impact of Iran's blockade in the Strait of Hormuz.

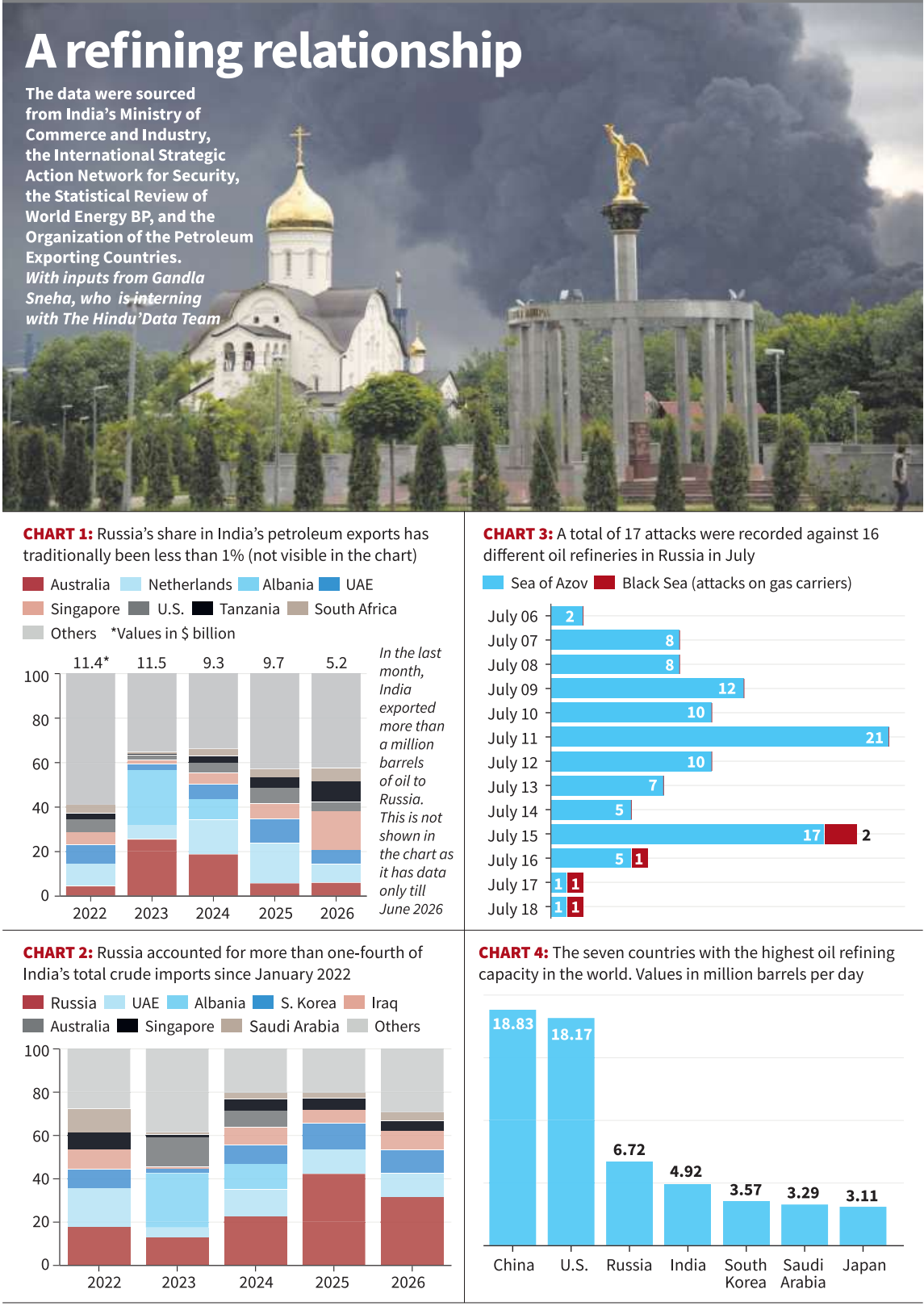
Chart 2 shows how Russia accounted for nearly one-third (31.6%) of India's crude imports as of June 2026. India imported \$531 million worth of crude from Russia in June 2026, which is roughly double that of its import from the country in January 2022, a month before Russia's invasion of Ukraine.

Amid Ukraine's continued targeting of Russia's oil refining infrastructure, the Russian Federation's Deputy Prime Minister Alexander Novak said in July that the country would begin importing oil products to help stabilise the domestic market.

Consistent attacks

According to the International Strategic Action Network for Security, there were at least 17 attacks on 16 different oil refineries in Russia. Eight attacks were targeted at oil depots and oil pumping stations in July (**Chart 3**). Though reliable data on similar attacks in August are not available yet, they seem to have continued at the same rate, resulting in petrol and diesel shortages.

Data from the Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries (OPEC) show that Russia's refinery crude throughput went from about 5.18 million barrels per day in Q12026 (January to March) in the beginning of the year, to about 3.88 million barrels per day in Q32026. The attacks also seem to have contributed to a surge in crude exports from Russia, as unplanned refinery outages diverted higher volumes of crude to the export market. India, which ranks fourth in oil-refining capacity in the world, has utilised Russia's sudden demand to export refined petroleum products, mainly from private refineries (**Chart 4**). Considering the time it would take for Russia to bring its refining capacity back to its earlier capacity, the surge in exports could continue, which will help India in easing its pressure on foreign exchange in the coming months.



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The *Hindu*.

FIFTY YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 3, 1976

Tip-off leads to underground vault

Madras, September 2: Sixteen exquisite bronze idols and 17 puja utensils all valued at Rs. one crore have been recovered from an underground vault in the ancient Kalyanasundarar Temple in Nallur, Papanasam taluk in Thanjavur district. The temple is under the control of the Tiruvaduthurai Adheenam.

Officials of the Hindu Religious and Charitable Endowments Department and State Directorate of Archaeology, led by Dr. R. Nagaswami, Director of Archaeology, acting on a hint thrown by the temple executive searched and found the vault. A representative of the Tiruvaduthurai Adheenam was present during the search. The Math's records indicate that these valuable images and jewels had been deposited in the safe vault in 1942.

These rare pieces of art were retrieved earlier this week after securing an order from the State Government to rummage the underground cell in the temple precincts.

Apart from the discovery of the valuable pieces from the subterranean chamber, this probe has given a clue to the traditional method of safeguarding precious idols and ornaments of a temple and the care bestowed on preservation of art forms.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 3, 1926

Slavery in Burma frontier

Rangoon, September 2: *The Rangoon Gazette* says that the successful emancipation of slaves in Hukawng valley last season will, it is said, be followed this cold season by an expedition to that part of unadministered territory between Malikha and Nmaikha rivers, north of their junction to the Irrawaddy river and locally known as the triangle where the same system of slavery as existed in Hukawng valley still prevails. The triangles though not as extensive a territory as Hukawng valley, is more densely populated and the number of slaves to be liberated will be more numerous. It is expected that Mr. J.T.O. Barnard, Deputy Commissioner, Burma, Frontier Service, who was principally responsible for the arrangements for the emancipation of the slaves in the Hukawng valley will be placed on this duty and in charge of the expedition. *The Gazette's* statement is yet unconfirmed.

CBI should probe ‘cash for transfer scam’ in Punjab: BJP

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Wednesday demanded the resignation of Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann and a Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) probe into the “cash for transfer” charges in the State.

There were serious allegations of institutional corruption in Punjab, BJP spokesperson Gaurav Bhatia said. Citing the purported findings of a probe by the Enforcement Directorate (ED), he alleged that money was being taken for the transfers and postings of senior bureaucrats and police officers.

Confidential government documents had reached middlemen, but despite seven letters from the ED, no FIR had been registered, the BJP leader said. He demanded the immediate resignation of Mr. Mann and a fair investigation by the CBI.

Claiming that Aam Aadmi Party chief Arvind Kejriwal and Mr. Mann “have today become symbols of corruption”, Mr. Bhatia alleged that senior Punjab officials were involved in the “scam”. “Their transfers



Gaurav Bhatia

and postings are carried out according to a rate card... This rate card fixes the price for who will get which charge and in which department they will be posted,” he said.

The facts presented by the ED before the Punjab and Haryana High Court in its affidavit revealed that confidential documents, draft lists of postings and transfers, and draft lists of government policies to be implemented in the future were found on WhatsApp on the mobile phones of alleged middlemen and touts, Mr. Bhatia said.

“The concerning aspect is that... the ED told the Punjab Police that this was a cognisable offence and that an FIR should be registered. However, despite seven letters being written to the Punjab Police, no FIR was registered,” he said.

Air Force veteran appointed first Ram Temple Trust CEO

Air Vice-Marshal Jitendra Mishra (ret'd) served in IAF for 31 years; Mahesh Bhagchandka, Madan Mohan Pandey, Nirmala Yadav named trustees; move comes amid allegation of donation theft

Ishita Mishra
NEW DELHI

The Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust on Wednesday appointed Air Vice-Marshal Jitendra Mishra (ret'd) as its first chief executive officer.

The appointment came at a time when the Trust is strengthening its administrative structure amid allegations of theft of donations at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya.

The appointment was announced after a meeting of the Trust at the Maniram Das Chawani in Ayodhya, where the trustees also filled three vacant positions on the Board.

The vacancies arose following the resignations of senior Vishwa Hindu Parishad (VHP) leader and general secretary Champat Rai, and trustee Anil Mishra. They quit in July after the embezzlement allegations surfaced.

The third vacancy arose after the death of trustee Vimlendra Pratap Mishra, a member of Ayodhya's erstwhile royal family.

According to a commu-



Air Vice-Marshal Jitendra Mishra (ret'd) was awarded the Sarvottam Yudh Seva Medal and was also a part of Operation Sindoor. PTI

nique issued by the Trust, Air Vice-Marshal Mishra was appointed following the recommendations of a committee constituted to select the CEO.

The process involved scrutinising about 5,585 applications, and interviewing hundreds of candidates over a period of nearly two months.

Air Vice-Marshal Mishra served in the Indian Air Force for 31 years, holding positions across different departments and gaining extensive leadership experience, the Trust said.

It added that the new CEO was also awarded the Sarvottam Yudh Seva Me-

dal, one of the highest military decorations for distinguished service in wartime. He was also part of Operation Sindoor.

‘Unaware of selection’

He had not been aware of his selection prior to the announcement made to the media on Wednesday, Air Vice-Marshal Mishra told *The Hindu*.

“I also got to know about my selection through television. I am elated,” he said.

The trustees also appointed three new members – Mahesh Bhagchandka, Madan Mohan Pandey, and Nirmala Yadav – to fill

the vacant positions. Mr. Bhagchandka is associated with Ashok Singhla Foundation, while Mr. Pandey is an advocate.

Ms. Yadav will be the first woman to hold a trusteeship in the Trust.

Swami Govind Dev Giri will continue as the Trust's general secretary, while Mr. Bhagchandka will take charge as treasurer. The Trust's annual accounts for 2025-26 have also been approved.

Financial details

The Trust recorded a total income of about ₹237 crore, and expenditure of about ₹99 crore during the financial year. It also incurred about ₹425 crore in capital expenditure on construction and related works. As of March 31, the Trust had total funds of about ₹1,882 crore.

The VHP hailed the appointment of the CEO. VHP president Alok Kumar described Air Vice-Marshal Mishra as a senior and respected personality, adding that his extensive experience would help the Trust function more effectively and transparently.

Provide security to rural communities before a crisis strikes, says Cong. chief

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge on Wednesday said rural communities should not be remembered only during droughts, floods, crop failures or elections, and called for a development model that provides them security before a crisis strikes.

He was speaking at an event organised by the Dr. Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy Foundation and the Dr. KVP Foundation, where the M.S. Swaminathan Research Foundation (MSSRF) was conferred the Dr. Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy Award, 2026.

Mr. Kharge said governments must ensure that farmers have fair markets, rural families have decent livelihoods, and women have economic indepen-



Big honour: Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge with Telangana Chief Minister Revanth Reddy in New Delhi on Wednesday. PTI

dence, while tribal communities and villages need access to technology, opportunities and basic infrastructure. “The government has an important role in creating this security, so that the communities become partners in India's development,” he said.

The Congress president also took a swipe at the

Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh. Without naming anyone, he said he had heard an RSS leader claim that India had witnessed many reforms. Mr. Kharge said it was the Congress that had carried out the reforms being referred to.

Linking the award to the legacies of Rajasekhara Reddy and agricultural

scientist M.S. Swaminathan, Mr. Kharge said both believed that development must ultimately serve the dignity of ordinary people.

Rajasekhara Reddy, he said, had worked for the poor and marginalised, while Swaminathan had sought to combine scientific advancement with social equity and environmental sustainability.

Paying tribute to Swaminathan, Mr. Kharge recalled his contribution to the Green Revolution and recalled how the late scientists had described Indira Gandhi as the “most successful warrior against hunger”.

In a video message, Soumya Swaminathan, chair of the MSSRF and daughter of M.S. Swaminathan thanked the organisers for conferring the award on the foundation.

Kapil Sibal seeks SC intervention over ‘bulk SIR deletions’

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Rajya Sabha member Kapil Sibal on Wednesday urged the Supreme Court to stop the “bulk deletions” taking place under the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

Mr. Sibal alleged that the ongoing SIR was aimed at helping the BJP win elections. In a post on X, he termed it “politics of exclusion”, and alleged that “BJP agents” were looking to “target Muslims, seek bulk deletions”. He added, “Supreme Court needs to stop this!”

Addressing a press conference here, Mr. Sibal cited a report from Jharkhand, alleging that the form to request the deletion of names from the voters' list was being filed in bulk by BJP workers.

“You can file bulk forms – you can take 45 of them,

or 100 of them, or even 400 of them. You can file the forms, and you can say that this name should be deleted. You don't have to give any reason for it, and if it is found to be false, it doesn't matter,” he said.

Earlier, *The Hindu* had reported that cases of Form 7 being submitted in bulk had surfaced in States like Rajasthan, Gujarat and Assam.

‘Serious issue’

Mr. Sibal alleged that many people whose names were sought to be deleted were Muslims and had been living in their area for years.

“Therefore, this is a very serious issue, and if courts don't take care of this issue, if courts just believe that the SIR exercise is by a neutral EC, then I think we are in deep trouble; this democracy will be in deep trouble,” the Rajya Sabha member said.

Former AIMIM leader joins Congress ahead of 2027 U.P. election

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Syed Asim Waqar, former spokesperson of the All India Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen (AIMIM), joined the Congress on Wednesday, alleging that the Asaduddin Owaisi-led party paid lip service to the objective of defeating the Bharatiya Janata Party while fighting the Opposition parties on the ground.

Mr. Waqar joined the Congress at the party headquarters here in the presence of All India Congress Committee (AICC) in-charge for Uttar Pradesh Rajendra Pal Gautam, State Congress president Ajay Rai and AICC Minority Department chairman Imran Pratapgarhi.

Explaining his decision, Mr. Waqar said his years in the AIMIM had convinced him that a party seeking to remove the BJP from pow-



Syed Asim Waqar

er could not simultaneously weaken those fighting the ruling party. “If we keep fighting the Opposition and do not allow it to grow, then we are helping the BJP,” Mr. Waqar said.

Mr. Rai said Mr. Waqar's induction would strengthen the party in Uttar Pradesh ahead of the 2027 Assembly election. A key AIMIM voice in Uttar Pradesh and considered close to Mr. Owaisi, Mr. Waqar's exit comes as the AIMIM seeks to expand its political footprint in the State.

Rahul takes stock of Maharashtra issues

Vinaya Deshpande Pandit
MUMBAI

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Wednesday sought a detailed assessment of key political issues in Maharashtra, including the deletion of names from the electoral rolls, Maratha and OBC reservation issues and tribal protests.

He is in Nashik for the

party's *Sanghatan Srujan Abhiyan*.

Later, Mr. Gandhi interacted with the families of the district Congress committee presidents before addressing the concluding session of the training camp. He urged the district presidents to expand the organisation and take the Congress's ideology to people across the State.

**MAHATRANSKO**
Maharashtra State Electricity Transmission Co. Ltd.

**INVITATION FOR BID (IFB)
(LOCAL COMPETITIVE BIDDING)**

SRM e-Tender No. T-2662/MSETCL/CO/Projects/Pre-Tender (RFx No. 6000001567) (2nd Call)
MSETCL invites offers by SRM e-tendering in TWO bid system (Techno-Commercial Bid and Price Bid) from the eligible registered bidders for the following work as detailed below.
“Establishment of 220/33kV Murmi (Dahegaon Bangla) S/S along with construction of LILo on existing 220kV Waluj Chitegaon SC line (RL-12.99km) at 220kV Murmi Substation, Tal. Gangapur, Dist. Ch. Sambhajinagar under Ch. Sambhajinagar Zone, MSETCL, Maharashtra.”
Interested bidders may obtain further information available on the website. <https://srmetender.mahatransco.in>
The date of downloading of Bid documents available on the website is from **31.08.2026**.
**Sd/-
Chief Engineer (Projects), MSETCL**

**BENGALURU CENTRAL CITY CORPORATION**
Office of the Executive Engineer, Shivaji Nagar Division, Thimmaiah Road, Queens Road, Bangalore

Tender NO. EE/SJN/E-PROC/27/2026-27
Date: 02.09.2026

**INVITATION FOR SHORT TERM TENDER
(TWO COVER SYSTEM)**
(Through GOK KPP Portal <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in> only)
The Executive Engineer (Shivaji Nagar Division), BCCC, Bangalore invites tenders from eligible Contractors registered in CPWD / KPWD / Railways /MES/ National Highway or any State Government Organizations for the construction of work detailed in the table below.
Standard Tender Document KW4.

Sl. No.	Name of the Work
1.	Heritage restoration, Reconstruction & development of Russel Market in Shivajinagara in Bengaluru City Amount Put to Tender : Rs.7,000.00 Lakhs. EMD : Rs.70,00,000.00.

Calendar of Events : (1) Tenders must be submitted online through e-procurement portal on or before **16.00 hours on 03.10.2026** and the opening of tenders will be as per the e-procurement portal guidelines. (2) Pre bid meeting will be held on **24.09.2026 at 15.00** in the office of the Chief Engineer Zone-2, Bengaluru City Central Palike, Annexure-3, 4th Floor, GBA office compound, N R Square, Bengaluru (3) Last Date for uploading the Filled Tender Document is **03.10.2026 upto 16.00pm**. (4) Date of Technical bid opening of Tenders is on **05.10.2026 by 11.00 am** (5) Date of Financial bid Opening of Tenders is on after Technical bid approved.
Sd/- Executive Engineer, Shivaji Nagar Division, BCCC

Cong. cites Garg's analysis to question GDP growth figures

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI



These claims cannot simply be dismissed. They come from someone who served as Finance and Economic Affairs Secretary of the Government under Modi between 2017 and 2019

PAWAN KHERA
Congress leader

The Congress on Wednesday stepped up its attack on the Union government over the latest GDP figures, citing reported remarks by former Finance Secretary Subhash Chandra Garg to argue that the Centre was using statistical revisions to present an inflated picture of economic growth.

Congress general secretary (communications) Jairam Ramesh shared a video clip of Mr. Garg, who said that revisions to the previous year's GDP had affected comparisons with the current year's figures.

According to Mr. Garg, without the revision, growth at current prices in the April-June quarter would have been around 2.6%, instead of the higher figure being projected.

Mr. Ramesh said the government's claims of robust economic growth, amplified through what he described as statistical “jugglery”, were at odds with conditions on the ground.

‘Burst the bubble’

“Former Finance Secretary Subhash Garg has now burst the bubble on this claim. His assessment is that the real GDP growth is around 2.6%, not 7.8%,” Mr. Ramesh said in a post on social media platform X. “The Modi government must understand: PR can polish the picture of GDP, but not the economy itself,” he said.

The Congress leader said the government needed to acknowledge the actual state of the economy and undertake reforms to

generate employment, strengthen MSMEs and private investment, raise demand and incomes, reduce inequality and ensure fair competition instead of promoting “crony capitalists”.

Mr. Ramesh said it was significant that questions were being raised over the GDP figures by a former Finance Secretary who had served in the Modi government.

Congress media and publicity department chairman Pawan Khera said Mr. Garg's assessment appeared closer to the “lived reality” of ordinary Indians, marked by rising prices, weakening purchasing power, shrinking disposable incomes and savings, stagnant employment opportunities and increasing household debt.

Seeks explanation

“These claims cannot simply be dismissed. They come from someone who served as Finance and Economic Affairs Secretary of the Government of India under Modi between 2017 and 2019,” Mr. Khera said, demanding an explanation for the revision of the previous year's GDP figures.

**Maharashtra State Agricultural Marketing Board,Pune (MSAMB)**

E-Tender Notice

MSAMB invites e-Tender for Construction of a Modern Primary Processing Center for Orange at Agricultural Produce Market Committee, Katol (Sub Market Khangoan), Taluka - Katol, Dist.Nagpur. Estimated cost of said work is Rs.625.23 Lakhs (GST extra). For details, please visit www.msamb.com and <https://mahatenders.gov.in>.
Managing Director

**MAHATRANSKO**
Maharashtra State Electricity Transmission Co. Ltd.

**INVITATION FOR BID (IFB)
(LOCAL COMPETITIVE BIDDING)**

SRM e-Tender No. T-2671/MSETCL/CO/Projects/Pre-Tender (RFx No. 6000001585) (2nd Call)
MSETCL invites offers by SRM e-tendering in TWO bid system (Techno-Commercial Bid and Price Bid) from the eligible registered bidders for the following work as detailed below.
“Establishment of 110/22kV Gaikwadpada GIS substation, Dist. Thane with associated lines using 220kV equipments and UG cable on turnkey basis under Vashi Zone, MSETCL, Maharashtra.”
Interested bidders may obtain further information available on the website. <https://srmetender.mahatransco.in>
The date of downloading of Bid documents available on the website is from **27.08.2026**.
**Sd/-
Chief Engineer (Projects), MSETCL**

**MAHATRANSKO**
Maharashtra State Electricity Transmission Co. Ltd.

**INVITATION FOR BID (IFB)
(LOCAL COMPETITIVE BIDDING)**

SRM e-Tender No. T-2681/MSETCL/CO/Projects/Pre-Tender (RFx No. 6000001579) (2nd Call)
MSETCL invites offers by SRM e-tendering in TWO bid system (Techno-Commercial Bid and Price Bid) from the eligible registered bidders for the following work as detailed below.
“Work of (A) Establishment of 400/220kV Kalwa GIS Substation along with reorientation of 400kV and 220kV lines & (B) Establishment of 400/220kV Padghe Split GIS Substation along with reorientation of 400kV and 220kV lines under Vashi Zone, MSETCL, Maharashtra.”
Interested bidders may obtain further information available on the website. <https://srmetender.mahatransco.in>
The date of downloading of Bid documents available on the website is from **27.08.2026**.
**Sd/-
Chief Engineer (Projects), MSETCL**

कार्यालय अधिशाषी अभियन्ता सा.नि.वि. खण्ड घाटोल
जिला बांसवाड़ा (राज.)

निविदा संशोधन
निविदा सूचना संख्या 07/2026-27
NIB CODE:- PWD262742362

इस खण्ड कार्यालय के पत्रांक 499 दिनांक 14.08.2026 द्वारा आमंत्रित निविदा सूचना संख्या 07/2026-27 में दलित कार्य संख्या 1 एवं 4 में विधिल कार्य हेतु अनुमानित लागत राशि एवं बरोहर राशि में विनियुक्त संशोधन किया जाता है :-

कार्य क्रम संख्या	पूर्व निर्धारित अनुमानित लागत (लाखों में)	पूर्व निर्धारित बरोहर राशि (लाखों में)	संशोधित अनुमानित लागत (लाखों में)	संशोधित बरोहर राशि (लाखों में)
1	42.50	8500	21250	42.52
2	32.66	65320	16330	38.54

नोट- निविदा की शेष राशि मूल निविदा सूचना अनुसार रहेगी।
(सोपान विवरण)
अधिशाषी अभियन्ता सा.नि.वि. खंड घाटोल
DIPRC/15544/2026

**MAHATRANSKO**
Maharashtra State Electricity Transmission Co. Ltd.

**INVITATION FOR BID (IFB)
(LOCAL COMPETITIVE BIDDING)**

SRM e-Tender No. T-2681/MSETCL/CO/Projects/Pre-Tender (RFx No. 6000001579) (2nd Call)
MSETCL invites offers by SRM e-tendering in TWO bid system (Techno-Commercial Bid and Price Bid) from the eligible registered bidders for the following work as detailed below.
“Work of (A) Establishment of 400/220kV Kalwa GIS Substation along with reorientation of 400kV and 220kV lines & (B) Establishment of 400/220kV Padghe Split GIS Substation along with reorientation of 400kV and 220kV lines under Vashi Zone, MSETCL, Maharashtra.”
Interested bidders may obtain further information available on the website. <https://srmetender.mahatransco.in>
The date of downloading of Bid documents available on the website is from **27.08.2026**.
**Sd/-
Chief Engineer (Projects), MSETCL**

A CH-CHE



Bengaluru-based EV manufacturer Simple Energy on Wednesday unveiled Simple Wave, a new range of electric scooters aimed at family buyers. The range comprises three variants and is available in six colours – Pearl White, Coral Red, Twilight Black, Polar Blue, Dolphin Grey and Forest Green. The company claims the scooters offer an IDC range of up to 243 km and storage capacity of up to 70 litres. Prices start at ₹1,09,999 (ex-showroom).

Danish biosolutions company Novonosis has announced an investment of ₹6,660 crore (€600 million) to expand its facility at Patalganga in Maharashtra and establish an advanced enzyme production facility. The expansion is aimed at increasing the company's production capacity to meet growing global demand for biosolutions. The new facility, which is expected to be fully operational by 2030, will manufacture enzymes for a range of industries, including biofuels.

Essel Group Chairman Subhash Chandra on Wednesday opposed the formation of a five-member bench by the NCLT to decide his personal insolvency case, contending that the tribunal does not have the power to constitute such a bench. Appearing for Mr. Chandra before the appellate tribunal NCLAT, Senior Advocate Sasmit Patra termed the NCLT order “faulty and wrong” and said, “they are not empowered” to form a five-member bench. PTI

M. Soundariya Preetha
COIMBATORE

Textile mills are witnessing a revival in cotton-yarn demand with capacity utilisation crossing 90% but a sharp rise in cotton prices is raising concerns over operational sustainability.

“Cotton yarn demand started reviving almost five months ago and now, mills are not holding much yarn stocks,” said Durai Palanisamy, chairman, Southern India Mills Association.

Cotton prices had risen sharply since mid-March, with local prices moving in line with ICE Futures, he said, adding mills had relatively low inventories with most maintaining less than two months stock.

Cotton prices which ranged between ₹51,700-₹57,000 a candy between October last and end March 2026 surged to ₹70,000/candy on September 2 on an ex-gin basis.

“Factors such as higher demand from China and likely lower output from the U.S. and China are pushing up prices,” said Nishant Asher, secretary, Indian Cotton Federation.

"Our cotton yarn cannot be used fully by local apparel sector. Textile mills need global opportunities for viable operations. Yarn prices adjust to cotton prices. Globally, too, yarn availability is under pressure, boosting prices," said Ravi Sam, vice-chairman, Cotton Textile Export Promotion Council.

Sources said Indian cotton prices were lower than global prices. The Cotton Corporation of India, which procured huge quantities of cotton at minimum support price, must stabilise prices.

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

Consultations are on for introducing a new tender for wind offshore technology in Tamil Nadu, Rajesh Kulkarni, Joint Secretary, Union Renewable Ministry told reporters here.

Mr. Kulhari said feasibility studies conducted in the State had yielded positive results.

"All [feasibility] studies have been completed in Tamil Nadu. The good news is capacity utilisation factor is more than 50%," he stated, adding, "collection of required data for offshore wind off the coast of Tamil Nadu, that is, wind velocity, geo-technical and geo-physical – have been completed by the National Institute of Wind Energy (NIWE)."

Sanjana B
BENGALURU

Almost a quarter of PayPal's about 6,700 India staff have either been laid off or are in the process of being laid off, sources said.

A PayPal spokesperson said, "The recent staffing changes are part of previously announced multi-year transformation to simplify global operations, strengthen execution and position the firm for long-term growth. We are committed to supporting staff through this transition."

In May, media reports

Reuters
NEW DELHI

VinFast suspended plans to make three electric vehicles in India and ordered suppliers to halt work on the projects while it reviews costs, as per sources and a memo reviewed by *Reuters* – a year after Vietnam's automaker entered the crucial growth market.

VinFast asked suppliers to “hold all activities” on three programmes, including a two-door SUV called VF 3 – expected to be its most competitive model in the market – and VF 6 and VF 7 SUVs, which it imports from Vietnam and assembles in the country.

The suspension marks another setback for loss-making VinFast which turned to India after difficulties in gaining market shares in U.S. and Europe.



Cushioning impact: The RBI has already begun absorbing rupee liquidity to ensure call rates did not fall below policy rate. REUTERS

The RBI had introduced a special USD-INR forex swap facility covering these instruments on June 8 this year to deal with forex outflows due to high oil prices and flight of capital owing to exit of Foreign

Portfolio Investors (FOIs)
from the stock market.

The central bank may prioritise closing its \$137-billion short forward dollar positions with the FCNR (B) deposits received, according to experts and in-

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Japan Credit Rating Agency (JCR) has upgraded India's credit rating by one notch from BBB+ to 'A-', it announced on Wednesday, on the back of India's relatively high growth, the government's growth-oriented policies, and the improved strength of the financial system.

FinMin welcomes

The Ministry of Finance has issued a statement welcoming the development,

saying that this comes against the backdrop of a challenging global environment.

A higher rating means that India can borrow at lower costs in the future, leading to a lower interest burden on the exchequer.

“The Indian economy has maintained a high

growth rate of around 7%, supported by robust private consumption and public investment,” JCR said in its rationale for the ratings upgrade. “The government of India has steadily implemented policies conducive to productivity growth and economic development, including the development of digital public infrastructure and the implementation of the goods and services tax (GST), strengthening the country’s economic foundations as compared to the past,” it added.

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Quebec-based La Caisse pension fund announced on Wednesday that it was acquiring a 24% stake in Altius Telecom Infrastructure Trust, India's largest trust through which tower and other telecom infrastructure spending is directed. The acquisition entails a CA\$1.76 billion investment, or ₹12,100 crore.

Canadian investment management MNC Brookfield remains the SEBI-registered Infrastructure Investment Trust (InvIT)'s largest shareholder.

‘Reflective of demand’

In a statement alongside Brookfield, La Caisse said that its acquisition “reflects growing demand for mobile connectivity and 5G infrastructure in India”.

The pension fund added, “India is the world’s second-largest telecommunications market, and continued growth in mobile data use and 5G is increasing the need for digital infrastructure.”

While two of the three private telecom operators have spread their 5G networks throughout every district in India in record time, infrastructure spending is expected to grow as many sites are not directly connected through fiber optic cables, and more sites need to be added to expand coverage in semi-urban and rural areas to meet growing traffic demand by users.



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HONG KONG

Hong Kong activist Joshua Wong pleads guilty to ‘foreign collusion’



Prominent Hong Kong pro-democracy activist Joshua Wong pleaded guilty on Wednesday to conspiracy to collude with foreign forces to endanger national security under a Beijing-imposed law. It was the second prosecution of Mr. Wong, a former student leader in the pro-democracy movement. AP

ISTANBUL

‘Mechanism needed for Black Sea safety before grain crisis escalates’



Turkiye’s President Tayyip Erdogan said on Wednesday a mechanism is needed to permanently ensure the safety of commercial maritime transport in the Black Sea before a grain crisis escalates. “The safety of all civilian maritime transportation in the Black Sea is important to us,” Mr. Erdogan said. REUTERS

KYIV

11 injured in Kyiv as Russian attacks continue for seventh straight day



Russian drones tore into central Kyiv on Wednesday morning, wounding 11 people and damaging residential and university buildings on the seventh day of nearly round-the-clock attacks. Russian President Vladimir Putin said he had ordered his forces to prepare the new campaign of “massive” strikes. REUTERS

BUNIA

Congo’s Ebola outbreak shows no signs of slowing; deaths top 3,000



Congo’s Ebola outbreak has killed more than 3,000 people out of over 6,100 cases, the government data showed on Wednesday, as the disease is spreading at an unprecedented speed, faster than efforts to slow it. It was declared a global health emergency in May and remains the fastest-growing outbreak of Ebola ever. AP

Iran fires on its Gulf neighbours in retaliation for renewed U.S. strikes

Tehran says four members of Revolutionary Guard and 10 of the Basij forces killed in U.S. attacks; Israel’s Defence Minister warns of ‘strong independent response’ if attacked; U.S. President suggests Strait of Hormuz be renamed ‘Trump Strait’

Associated Press
DUBAI

Iran fired on U.S. allies in the Gulf early Wednesday following a night of American bombardment that Iranian officials say included a deadly strike on a wedding party. Fighting has escalated since the American military hit Iranian rocket launchers on an island in the Strait of Hormuz over the weekend. Iran retaliated by firing missiles at American bases in Jordan that were intercepted. Kuwait and Bahrain said they had also come under attack, without reporting any casualties.



The aftermath of a U.S. strike on a wedding ceremony in southern Sirik county in Hormozgan province in Iran on Wednesday. AFP

“You will soon see that Iran’s new strategy on the battlefield, in diplomacy, and in confronting the economic blockade will shatter your foundations,” the recently appointed head of Iran’s powerful Supreme National Security Council, Mohsen Rezaei, said on X. Separately, Iran has said four members of its para-

military Revolutionary Guard and 10 members of the Guard’s volunteer Basij forces died in the U.S. attacks. In Iraq, where Iranian-backed forces are active, Kurdish authorities said they had intercepted 10 drones laden with explosives in the Erbil area. Iranian television reported that American bases in Erbil had been targeted. Israel’s military also said that Iran-backed Hezbollah fired two explosive drones at its soldiers in southern Lebanon, without causing casualties. Israel’s Defence Minister Israel Katz said on Wednesday his country was pre-

pared to “respond with great force, independently of anyone else” if attacked by Iran, adding “our planes are ready to take off”. “Trump Strait” U.S. President Donald Trump on Wednesday suggested renaming the Strait of Hormuz as “Trump Strait” despite the fact that the crucial waterway remains contested. “Now that we have it under U.S.A. control, should we change the name Hormuz Strait to TRUMP STRAIT??? Like America itself, it would be ‘hotter’ than ever before!” Mr. Trump said on his Truth Social network.

Hopes of finding survivors dim week after Nepal flood

Reuters
KATHMANDU

Hopes of finding more survivors among the thousands still missing in Nepal were fading, authorities said on Wednesday, a week after a glacier collapse in the Himalayas unleashed flash floods that devastated the mountainous nation. At least 1,114 people have been killed and nearly 4,000 remain unaccounted for, with officials fearing many are buried under debris left by the floods that tore through towns and valleys near the Chinese border. Across the border in Tibet, China’s official toll has held steady since Sunday at 16 dead and 546 missing. “The hope of finding survivors is decreasing,” Phanindra Paudel, a senior official at the government’s National Emergency Operation Centre (NEOC), said.



Nepalese soldiers work during a relief operation outside a tunnel near the hydropower project sites in Rasuwa district. REUTERS

“We pray and are hopeful. Hope is hope!” Rescuers are trying to find survivors believed to be trapped inside the tunnels of several hydroelectric plants, whose powerhouses have spaces and rooms for people to stay, Army spokesperson Raja Ram Basnet said. Authorities said 279 people had been rescued from the ruins of hydropower projects but at least 639 more were still missing, some of whom are believed to be trapped in tunnels. Prime Minister Balendra Shah said the focus would shift from search, rescue and relief operations towards rehabilitation and reconstruction. UN spokesperson Stephane Dujarric said aid agencies were “very concerned” about the growing public health risk.

U.S.-Sri Lanka operation busts drug network

Press Trust of India
COLOMBO

A joint operation by Sri Lankan and U.S. authorities busted a Pakistan-based narco-trafficking network allegedly attempting to smuggle drugs valued at \$21 million. Acting on intelligence about suspicious maritime containers being shipped from Pakistan to Colombo, the joint team seized the crystal methamphetamine concealed in bath towels, a U.S. Embassy release said.

Taliban defend ban on protests, saying it ‘does not exist in Islamic law system’

Agence France-Presse
KABUL

The Taliban defended on Wednesday its ban on protests that has drawn condemnation from rights groups, saying the order complies with Islamic law. Demonstrations in Afghanistan have been rare since the Taliban returned to power just over five years ago, but the government last month introduced a rule holding that “all types of protests are banned”. International organisations have decried the law



as “ruthless” and a move to suppress any dissent in the country. Taliban regime spokesperson Zabihullah Mujahid said during a news conference that the “law fully

complies with Islamic law”, adding that “protests don’t exist in Islamic law”. “Protests belong to societies where there are different laws established, for example a democracy or a republic,” he said. Under the Islamic system, he said, people can approach the government with concerns rather than hold demonstrations. Mr. Mujahid argued the ban “will also protect people from wasting time” and prevent the destruction of private property. Human Rights Watch late last month slammed

the ban as “another step in the Taliban’s ruthless effort to suppress all dissent”. Amnesty International described the Taliban’s broader series of changes to law enforcement as “another sweeping assault on human rights in Afghanistan”, calling the protest ban “among its most egregious provisions”. While demonstrations are rare, at least two persons were killed in June when security forces reportedly opened fire on a women’s rights protest in the western city of Herat, a group of UN experts said.

BENGALURU CO-OP. MILK UNION LTD., [BENGALURU DAIRY]
Dr. M.H. Marigowda Road, Bengaluru-560029
E-mail Address : bamulpurchase@gmail.com
Website: www.bamulnandini.coop Phone:080-26096214 & 282

Tender Ref No: BAMUL/PUR/09/1853/T-359/2026-27

Date: 02.09.2026

SHORT-TERM TECHNICAL CUM COMMERCIAL TENDER THROUGH KARNATAKA PUBLIC PROCUREMENT PORTAL

Bengaluru Co-op Milk Union Ltd., (BAMUL) Bengaluru, invites e-tender through e-Procurement Portal from the interested and eligible Manufacturers/Contractor/Dealer/Distributors for Supply of the following item.

Sl. No.	Particulars	Qty	Estd Cost in Lakhs	Tender No
01	Design Supply Installation Testing And Commissioning Of Plastic Blown Pouch Film Plant at Bengaluru Dairy.	01 Lot (Lumpsum)	2200.00	KMF/2026-27/IND2324/Call-3
1	Access to E-tender Documents	03.09.2026 to 10.09.2026 till 02.00 PM		
2	Pre-Bid Meeting /Tender clarification date & time	05.09.2026 till 11.00 AM		
3	Last date for submission of tender/ quoting	10.09.2026 till 02.00 PM		
4	Date & time for opening Technical Tender	11.09.2026 at 02.05 PM		
5	Date & time for opening Commercial Tender	15.09.2026 at 11.00 AM		
6	Place of opening of Technical and Commercial Tender	BAMUL (Bengaluru Dairy) Board Room		

The Tenderers shall submit separate tender for the above, Tenderers are advised to note the qualification criteria specified in Section VII to qualify for award of the contract.

The Earnest money deposit (E.M.D.) valid for 45 days beyond the validity of the tender i.e. total for 135 days, Tender processing Fee, modes of e-payment, tender document details and other details are mentioned in <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in> and also contact Help line No: 8046010000 /8068948777

Sd/- Managing Director

Tender Inviting Authority, Bamul

GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA - DEPARTMENT OF WATER RESOURCES
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF CONSTRUCTION ENGINEER,
KANUPUR IRRIGATION PROJECT
AT/PO-BASUDEVPUR, DIST-KEONJHAR, ODISHA, PIN-758047
e-mail: ccekippur@gmail.com

"e"- PROCUREMENT NOTICE - Bid Identification No.: CCE, KIP (KRCA&BD)-09/2026-27

(Pertaining to Kanpur Rehabilitation Campus & Building Division, Basudevpur)

1. Name of the Work	As per Detailed Tender Call Notice
2. Total No. of Package	05 (Five Nos. of individual Work)
3. Estimated Cost	559.90 to 690.56 Lakh
4. Period of completion	As per Detailed Tender Call Notice
5. Class of Contractor	"A" or "Special" Class Contractor as per Detailed Tender Call Notice
6. Date & Time of availability of bid document in the portal	Dt.03.09.2026 from 10.00 Hours to Dt.18.09.2026 up to 17.00 Hours.
7. Last date / Time for receipt of bids in the portal	18.09.2026 up to 17.00 Hours.
8. Date & Time of Opening of Tender (Technical Bid)	19.09.2026 at 11.00 Hours
9. Name and address of the Officer Inviting Bid	Er. Mahendra Kumar Behera Chief Construction Engineer, Kanupur Irrigation Project, At/Po.- Basudevpur, Dist.- Keonjhar, Odisha - 758047.

Further details can be seen from the e-Procurement portal "<https://www.tendersodisha.gov.in>"

(Er.Mahendra Kumar Behera)
Chief Construction Engineer,
Kanupur Irrigation Project, Basudevpur, Keonjhar, Odisha

32001/781/2627

OIPR-32001/32376/1/26-27/0006

ODISHA
NEW OPPORTUNITIES

OFFICE OF THE CHIEF GENERAL MANAGER (CIVIL),
IDCO, IDCO TOWER, BHUBANESWAR

Bid Identification No.Civil/EST-22/2026-27 : TCN No.25282, dt.25/08/2026

NOTICE INVITING TENDER UNDER NATIONAL COMPETITIVE BIDDING THROUGH e-Procurement

1. Name of the Work : Construction of Block Level Stadium (with Indoor Hall), in Kukudakhandi Block under Ganjam District.

2. Value of the Work : Rs.15.42 Crore

3. Period of completion : 12 (Twelve) Calendar Months

4. Availability of tender online for Bidding :

- Start Date : 18.00 Hours of dt.08.09.2026
- End Date : 15.00 Hours of dt.23.09.2026
- Opening date : 16.00 Hours of dt.23.09.2026.

Tender details can be seen from the e-procurement portal: www.tendersorissa.gov.in, Corrigendum or Addendum if any will not be published in newspapers and can be seen in e-procurement portal as well as in IDCO website.

Chief General Manager (Civil), IDCO, Bhubaneswar
4001/293/2627

Uttarakhand Tourism Development Board (UTDB)
Pandit Deendayal Upadhyay Paryatan Bhawan, Near O.N.G.C. Helipad, Nimbhawal, Garhi Cantt, Dehradun - 248003 (UK)
Ph. 0135-2559898, Fax 135-2559888

Ref. No. 3230/2-7-1020/2026-27

Dated: 02 September, 2026

UTDB invites tender for Supply of Ski Equipment to the Uttarakhand Tourism Development Board (UTDB), Dehradun, Uttarakhand

Details may be obtained on website: uktenders.gov.in and uttarakhandtourism.gov.in from 3:00 PM on 03.09.2026. Prospective Bidders may seek clarification till 03:00 PM on 08.09.2026 through E-mail: adventurewingutdb@gmail.com with CC to procurement.utdb@gmail.com. Any Addendum/Corrigendum including date extension will be uploaded only on uktenders.gov.in. Bids must be submitted online through uktenders.gov.in only. The last date for submission of bids is 26.09.2026 till 15:00 PM.

Chief Executive Officer

EALA MANIA

‘We’re very loud when it comes to supporting our people’



AP Alex Eala's fans arrived in huge numbers when she trained and then played in her first round US Open match. One of them was Andrea Belen, who FaceTimed with her father during the session so he could see Eala. “Everyone went crazy. We’re very loud when it comes to supporting our people,” said Belen.

DOUBLY SWEET

To play on the day of my 40th birthday was special: Monfils



AFF Gael Monfils stood in the middle of the court and bowed to the crowd that treated the Frenchman to a roaring ovation on his 40th birthday. “To play on the day of my 40th birthday was special. You guys made it incredible,” said Monfils to the fans at the Louis Armstrong Stadium, who sang happy birthday to him.

SHOWTIME

Frodin, Serena’s body double in *King Richard*, hogs the limelight



AP Thea Frodin once had to hit like Serena Williams in the *King Richard* movie in 2021. On Tuesday at the US Open, the 17-year-old showed some pretty good power of her own in real life. “Being aggressive has always been my game. Hopefully, the next time I meet her [Rybakina], I will see what I can do,” said Frodin.

IN THE HOTSEAT

Red Bull’s Lawson to race in Italian GP as injury keeps Hadjar out



REUTERS Liam Lawson will remain Max Verstappen’s teammate at Red Bull for the Italian GP after Isack Hadjar failed to recover in time from his wrist injury, the team confirmed. Hadjar had said he was hopeful of returning for Sunday’s race but will now miss a second event. Yuki Tsunoda gets a second race with Racing Bulls in Lawson’s seat.

Zverev battles back from the brink to subdue Sonogo

The top-seeded German was two points from defeat in the fourth set; French Open runner-up Cobolli also wins five-set marathon; Rybakina and Gauff move up with ease on rain-affected day

US OPEN

Agence France-Presse
NEW YORK

Top-seeded Alexander Zverev survived a scare, overcoming Lorenzo Sonogo in a wild-five setter at the US Open on Tuesday as Elena Rybakina and Coco Gauff advanced with ease.

Zverev fought off a determined challenge from Italy’s lowly ranked Sonogo, winning 6-4, 3-6, 6-7(7), 7-5, 6-4 in a tense all-court battle spiced by unlikely retrievals, impossibly angled winners and some inexplicable errors, which wrapped up on Arthur Ashe Stadium after four hours and 53 minutes at 1:55 in the morning.

“I’m just happy I won, that’s it. Incredible battle,” said Zverev, who was two points from defeat trailing 5-4 in the fourth set.

The German held serve and broke Sonogo in the next game, then earned the lone break of the fifth set to complete the win.

Fifth-seeded Flavio Cobolli, runner-up to Zverev at Roland Garros, rallied from two sets down for the first time in his career to beat Argentina’s Francisco Comesana 3-6, 2-6, 6-3, 6-4, 6-4.

Nerves didn’t seem to be a problem for ninth-seeded Taylor Fritz as he sailed past fellow American Darwin Blanch 6-3, 6-2, 6-4.

There was no such drama for women’s World No. 2 Rybakina and former champion Gauff. Rybakina, eyeing a third Grand Slam title and the top ranking, beat US teen Thea Frodin



REUTERS Finding his range: Zverev conjured up unlikely retrievals and hit impossibly angled winners.

IMPORTANT RESULTS

Men: Second round: 7-Medvedev bt Gorznyi (USA) 6-1, 6-3, 7-5; Michelsen (USA) bt 16-Nakashima (USA) 6-3, 6-4, 6-4. **First round:** 1-Zverev (Ger) bt Sonogo (Ita) 6-4, 3-6, 6-7(7), 7-5, 6-4; 13-Musetti (Ita) bt Fery (GBR) 6-3, 6-3, 7-5; 9-Fritz (USA) bt Blanch (USA) 6-3, 6-2, 6-4; 24-Cerundolo (Arg) bt Misolic (Aut) 6-4, 6-3, 7-5; 5-Cobolli (Ita) bt Comesana (Arg) 3-6, 2-6, 6-3, 6-4, 6-4. **Women: Second round:** 19-Paolini (Ita) bt Stefanini (Ita) 6-4, 6-1; 31-Fernandez (Can) bt Sawangkaew (Tha) 6-4, 6-1; 15-Shnaider bt Pliskova (Cze) 6-1, 6-3, 6-2.

Gauff showed off her immensely improved serve in a confident 6-3, 6-4 victory over 53rd-ranked Zeynep Sonmez of Turkey. Gauff blazed through the opening set before Sonmez upped her game, recovering an early break in the second and briefly tak-

ing the lead before Gauff regrouped. Kazakhstan’s Rybakina showed little sign of the left heel injury that forced her out of her quarterfinal in Cincinnati this month. She saved both break points she faced in a polished performance against the big-hitting if erratic

American, who was playing her first Grand Slam main draw match on a wild card.

Women’s French Open champion Mirra Andreeva also advanced easily, cruising past Indonesia’s 36th-ranked Janice Tjen 6-2, 6-2.

Keys, a former Australian Open winner who lost in the first round at Flushing Meadows last year, conquered first-match jitters to beat 19-year-old Russian Alina Korneeva 7-5, 6-4.

While play went as scheduled on the covered Ashe and Armstrong stadiums, those on outside courts – including Rybakina – had to wait out some lengthy rain delays.

That included a near four-hour delay to the start of play and more delays in the evening. Five late matches were postponed altogether and a handful of others suspended.

DULEEP TROPHY

N. Sudarshan
BENGALURU

An omnipresent Tilak Varma fashioned South Zone’s entry into the 2026-27 Duleep Trophy final with a thumping seven-wicket triumph over North Zone at the BCCI Centre of Excellence here. The 23-year-old from Hyderabad, who had starred in the first innings with an ultra-patient, unbeaten 116 (250b), scored a breezy half-century (51 n.o., 79b, 8x4) on Wednesday to help South chase 181 and set up a final date with East Zone in Chennai starting this Sunday.

Tilak first batted during a nervous few minutes towards the end of day one. He then occupied the crease for the whole of day two, helped swell South’s first-innings lead to 117 on day three before coming up with a first-rate finishing act on the final day.

And when he was not batting, he was marshalling his team’s resources as cap-



K. MURALI KUMAR The orchestrators: After Nidheesh restricted North’s lead, South skipper Tilak, left, took over.

tain, making it an all-encompassing show.

North began the final morning from 256 for seven, ahead by 139 runs. But Kerala pacer M.D. Nidheesh cleaned up the tail to

and N. Jagadeesan (43, 83b, 4x4) set South on course before Tilak and R. Smaran (32 n.o., 42b, 4x4, 1x6) combined for an unbroken 80-run stand.

Tilak drove beautifully, almost always getting to the pitch of the ball and caressing the red cherry. His batting range could be seen in the back-to-back fours off left-arm spinner Abid Mushtaq, one reverse-swept and the other padded. North was tardy on the field. There were misfields galore, and as many as 12 byes, with Kanhaiya Wadhawan and Abdul Samad alternating wicket-keeping duties. The spiciest moment came when pacer Gurnoor Brar was livid with Wadhwan for dropping Jagadeesan on 14. It would have helped if Brar’s aggression had percolated through the side, but it never did.

The scores: North Zone 195 & 297 in 72.4 overs (Sanat Sangwan 76, Ayush Doseja 52, M.D. Nidheesh 5/56) lost to South Zone 312 & 182/3 in 43.1 overs (Ricky Bhui 42, N. Jagadeesan 43, Tilak Varma 51 n.o.).

Tilak says he wants to play in the final

N. Sudarshan
BENGALURU

South Zone skipper Tilak Varma expressed hope that he would be able to play the Duleep Trophy final against East Zone in Chennai starting this Sunday despite the short turnaround time between the marquee contest and the first T20I versus Afghanistan.

Tilak, who is India’s T20 vice-captain, will have to finish the final on September 10 and travel to Delhi for the international game scheduled for the 13th. East skipper Ishan Kishan and his deputy Vaibhav Sooryavanshi are also in the same boat.

“I want to play in the final,” Tilak told reporters on Wednesday after the triumph over North Zone. “We have two days break in between. But it depends

on the selectors and the management.”

Tilak hoped that speedster Vidwath Kaverappa, who didn’t take the field starting from the post-tea session on day three (Tuesday), will be available.

“His [left] ankle is slightly swollen, but he can walk and he is also running with a tape. I feel he will be there in the final. But let’s see.”

Karnataka stalwart Karun Nair, who scored 699 runs in the 2025-26 Ranji Trophy, was benched for the semifinal to accommodate Hyderabad’s K. Himateja. Tilak said it was purely because of team combination.

“North had two left-arm spinners, and we wanted a lefty in the middle-order. Himateja is a youngster (24) and has scored decent runs (485). It was very unfortunate for Karun.”

Mumbai, Vadodara to host first women’s CT

Agencies
DUBAI

The International Cricket Council (ICC) announced on Wednesday that the inaugural women’s Champions Trophy 2027 will be held in Mumbai and Vadodara from Feb. 14 to 28.

Top six outfits

Mumbai’s Cricket Club of India (CCI) and the Vadodara International Cricket Stadium will be the venues for the tournament which will bring together six of

the world’s top sides – Australia, England, India, New Zealand, South Africa and Sri Lanka. The teams, which qualified as per their ICC T20I rankings on the July 6 qualification cut-off date, will play in a round-robin league. The top two will progress to the final on February 28.

“With a marquee ICC women’s event now taking place every year, we have an opportunity to build greater momentum for the women’s game,” said Jay Shah, ICC chairman.

Stakeholders to meet today to chart India’s roadmap till ODI World Cup

Amol Karhadkar
MUMBAI

The Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) will convene a critical stock-taking meeting of key stakeholders of India’s men’s cricket teams at its headquarters here on Thursday.

It is understood that the meeting will seek to take a deep dive into the issues that have affected India’s performances of late and chart a roadmap through to next year’s ODI World Cup, including a possible extension of chief selector Ajit Agarkar’s tenure.

Multiple sources in the BCCI have confirmed that head coach Gautam Gambhir, Agarkar, Centre of Excellence head of cricket V.V.S. Laxman, captains Shubman Gill and Shreyas



Agarkar’s extension as chief selector will be discussed. FILE PHOTO: EMMANUEL YOGINI

Iyer, and BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia will attend the meeting in person. Two key BCCI executives are also expected to be present, while some other office-bearers may join via videoconference.

Having taken charge in July 2023, Agarkar’s current contract expires at the

end of this month. With BCCI regulations capping a selector’s tenure at four years, he is eligible to continue until next September.

That would ensure continuity through the ODI World Cup, scheduled to begin in October 2027. However, India’s poor returns in ODIs and the cold war between Agarkar and the BCCI hierarchy over Rohit Sharma’s future in international cricket are likely to feature in the deliberations.

The injury-management mechanism at the CoE is another area that has come under criticism from the selection committee and team management. As a result, despite the recent PR overdrive around the CoE, BCCI office-bearers are keen to proactively come

up with a plan for a more effective injury-management system.

Scheduling overlaps between key India-A and international assignments and major domestic fixtures are also expected to be discussed. India-A’s shadow tour of New Zealand coinciding with the ODI series against the Kiwis has left little room for adequate Test preparation ahead of the crucial series in November.

The poor run of the limited-overs teams in Ireland and England will also come under detailed scrutiny. Saikia had announced a review meeting immediately after the England tour concluded in mid-July, but it could not be convened because of the unavailability of key personnel.

From the Wall to the Hall

Once a boy who broke racquets and scrubbed toilets for it, Federer turned a hot temper into quiet grace and routine brilliance into religion, becoming tennis' closest thing to a spiritual experience. In Newport on Sunday, the Hall of Fame simply made it scripture

Anirudh Velamuri

There should be a word for what Roger Federer did on a tennis court, because “played” barely covers it. Watching him felt like being granted a glimpse of the divine, and that’s no exaggeration. Your jaw went slack, your eyes bulged, and sounds escaped your body that no grown adult should make over a man hitting a felt ball with a string racquet.

Federer did not invent anything. Every shot in his arsenal had been struck before, by someone else in some other era.

Yet, in his hands, the borrowed became the sacred, the familiar became revelation, as if the shot had been waiting its whole life for him specifically to unlock it. And he didn’t do it once in some career-defining flash of magic. He did it for the better part of two decades. It was a residency in genius, not a hot streak. Pete Sampras once said Federer’s game had no weaknesses, and it stands true. What other players built entire careers on – a single jaw-dropping moment etched into a highlight reel – Federer treated as routine.

Except, of course, that routine came around roughly a thousand times, spread across four Grand Slams and every corner of the world, and it never once stopped feeling like the first time. That is the strange arithmetic of Federer’s greatness: repetition should have dulled the wonder, but it never did. Familiarity, in his case, only sharpened the awe.

Now the residency has its plaque. The felt ball has been put down, the sermons have ended, and what’s left is the reckoning every great career eventually meets – not a match, but a monument.

On Sunday, the world celebrated Federer once again as he was inducted into the International Tennis Hall of Fame. It is the sport’s great farewell and its eternal afterlife in the same breath, a place where a player’s brilliance is carved into permanence, even as it reminds them that greatness is never solitary.

The crowd said as much. Billie Jean King, Martina Navratilova, Stefan Edberg, John McEnroe, Andy Roddick and many others were on hand to celebrate one of tennis’ finest champions.

And closer still sat the ones who needed no introduction. His parents, Robert and Lynette. His wife, Mirka, and his four kids that the tennis world had watched grow up, one Slam at a time, in players’ boxes scattered across the globe—.

Mirka spoke first and introduced her husband with a line that outshone every statistic that followed. “What makes me proudest isn’t what Roger accomplished when the world was watching. It’s who he is when nobody’s watching,” she said.

He, too, glowingly praised the one person who has seen the highs and lows of his stardom from a touch away, while also building a semblance of a normal life together.

“Mirka inspires me every day. She showed me how to stay focused on tennis and take joy in everything else. A wonderful mother to our four kids... she makes the impossible happen. We grab each other’s hands, and we run through walls.”

More than trophies

For once, the man who made the impossible look routine was undone by his own history. He tried, and failed, to hold it together – pausing a few times to wipe his eyes, half-laughing through his tears. At one point, he pleaded for tissues and sunglasses, but pressed on anyway, the way he always had.

When he steadied himself enough, he spoke not of the trophies or numerous records. He was more focused on the more than 5,000 headbands he wore, the more than 7,000 pairs of socks he went through, some 10,000 racquets strung over the years, and the thousands of sets played on the same two knees.

“I tried to show my love for the game. Because it really mattered to me, and I also wanted it to matter to you. To be worthy of your attention, worthy of your attendance, because people don’t have to come watch us play. They come to be entertained, inspired, excited. They could always decide to go somewhere else, but they chose tennis, they chose us,” he emphasised.

The 45-year-old even wandered back to where it all began, not in any packed



stadium but in the shadows just off it.

“I remember being a ball boy in Basel, standing against the back wall, hands behind me, eyes on the ball. I’ll never forget how the game looked from there... the intensity, the adversity, the feeling of being so close to the players. I remember the next morning, my legs were gone... standing all day is a lot of work.”

Federer, especially later in his career, had the power to make the smallest cog in the wheel seen and appreciated. His core memory helped him do the same once more at Newport.

“I really want to thank every ball kid who ever stood through my matches or all our matches, for that matter, for hours on end. I see you. I thank you. I was you.”

It’s a strange, fitting symmetry: that is precisely how everyone felt watching his career unfold. Standing still, eyes fixed on the ball, absorbing the intensity as though they were pressed against the back wall of the court – even from several hundred or several thousand kilometres away, on the other side of the television screen.

More than a hundred titles in his cabinet, and yet Federer insisted the number was never the point.

“They call this the Hall of Fame... but fame was never the goal. My goal was to spend my life doing something I love, with people who love it as much as I do.”

And he did – relentlessly, joyfully, for the better part of his life. Federer didn’t just win; he took tennis to altitudes it hadn’t

reached before, wrote storylines the sport had never dared to script, and handed the world rivalries (with Rafael Nadal and Novak Djokovic) that will be studied and mythologised for generations.

Smashed racquet, softened man

There was a time when the future maestro was closer to a menace. As a boy in Basel, he didn’t play tennis so much as wage a war with it – swearing between points, smashing racquets and the whole kit and caboodle. At 16, he tore through a practice backdrop, understandably earning a week-long toilet-scrubbing sentence from his coach.

By his own admission, the unlearning took years and was no epiphany. The real turning point wasn’t a victory or defeat, but a tragedy – the death of his childhood coach Peter Carter in 2002, which recalibrated Federer for good.

Self-deprecation became an art form, just like most things would with Federer. The same man, on Sunday, would hold up two ageing knees to a crowd of legends and grin, saying, “Still got them, by the way. If I fall, please catch me.” The once hot-headed boy is now at ease with

laughing at himself, and became the most graceful man in tennis – on the court and off it. And he did it all with the same unhurried smile, even in the moments when the headband was fighting a losing battle against the sweat of another title run, even when his body was being pushed past what bodies are supposed to give.

“I’m still writing my love letter to tennis. My time as a player is done, but tennis will always stand at the intersection of everything I care most about... my family, our friendships, the past 40 years and the future we’re building. So this is not a goodbye,” he stated.

“We all leave the court eventually, but the sport keeps evolving. This boy from Basel thanks you... and I thank all of you for sharing the journey.”

It is the tennis world, though, that owes its thanks to Federer.

He carried the sport to spaces it had never been invited into before – into living rooms of people who couldn’t tell a forehand from a backhand, into the vocabulary of art critics and poets who had never once written about sport, into a kind of beauty that made the utilitarian business of winning feel almost secondary. He turned rivalry into reverence, opponents into co-authors, and a simple racquet into something closer to a paintbrush.

The ball boy became the main event. And the boy who once stood against the back wall, eyes fixed on the ball with hands behind his back, has finally taken his place among the very heroes he once watched from the shadows.

That, perhaps, is the only ending fitting enough: not a farewell, but a homecoming.

Career in numbers

1 The only male player to appear in seven consecutive Wimbledon finals (2003 to 2009)

8 Federer holds the record for most Wimbledon men’s singles titles

19 Grass was Federer’s most successful surface, where he won an Open Era record 19 titles (including a record 10 Halle Open titles)

20 Number of Grand Slam singles titles he won. He is the first man in history to reach the milestone

31 The number of Grand Slam finals reached (20-11 win-loss record)

56 His record win streak on hard courts (2005 ABN AMRO World Tennis Tournament in Rotterdam to the 2006 Dubai Duty Free Tennis Championships)

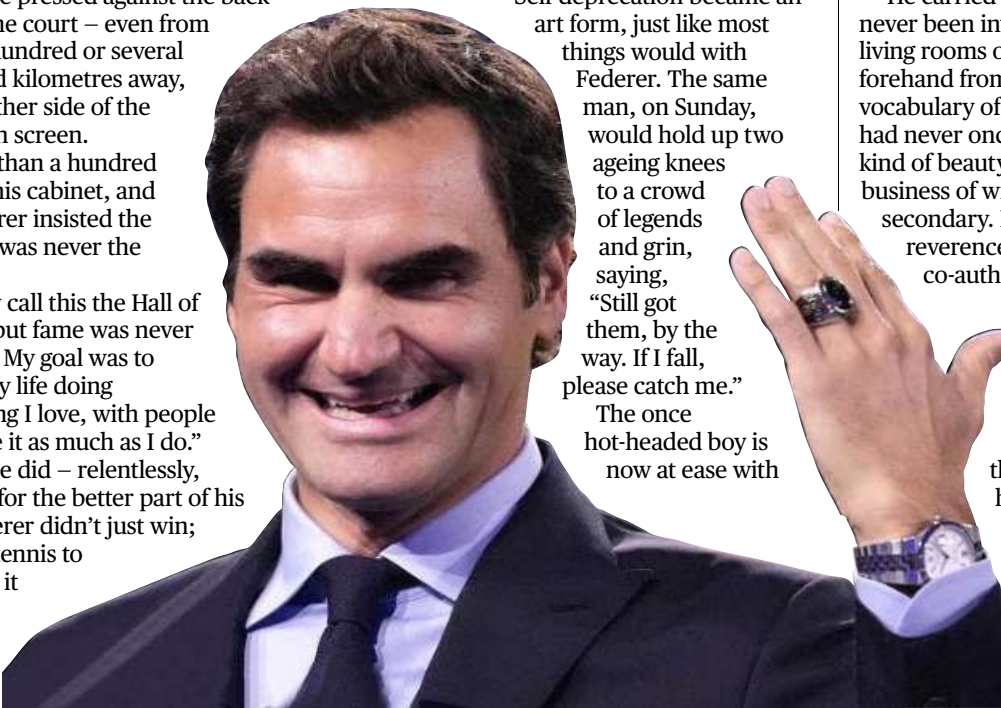
103 Number of career titles won

224 Career victories against top-10 opponents, with a 64.6 win percentage

237 Holds the record for most consecutive weeks as World No. 1 (February 2, 2004 to August 17, 2008)

310 Number of weeks spent as the top-ranked player in the world, second only to Djokovic (428)

1,526 The number of matches Federer played (won 1,251 and lost 275)



Moving towards a universal vaccine against pneumonia and meningitis

Scientists are looking for a universal pneumococcal vaccine that can target all the hundred or so forms of *Streptococcus pneumonia* bacteria, and prevent some undesirable outcomes created by existing vaccines that keep the threat of pneumococcal diseases alive in the human population

S. Swaminathan

There is a bacterium called *Streptococcus pneumoniae*. It comes in at least a hundred different forms, or serotypes, and lives in the tissue lining our nose and throat. *S. pneumoniae* is normally harmless. But when your body's immune system becomes weaker, for example when you have a viral fever, these bacteria may invade your lungs and cause pneumonia, your brain and spinal cord to cause meningitis, and your bloodstream to cause sepsis.

These diseases are called pneumococcal diseases, and fortunately, they can be prevented by vaccines. Each of these vaccines contains a unique sugary substance called a capsular polysaccharide, aimed at each serotype of *S. pneumoniae*. That is, they offer protection specific to each serotype.

And the current crop of pneumococcal vaccines protect against only a subset of the 100-odd serotypes. To increase coverage, scientists need to include additional serotype-specific capsular polysaccharides in the vaccine. And covering all the serotypes in a single shot would be extremely challenging, not to mention extremely expensive as well.

Sugary shot

Recently, a team of British scientists reported an important first step in this direction. They did two things: first, they switched the polysaccharide with proteins and, second, they adopted an approach called reverse vaccinology.

Basically, two kinds of pneumococcal vaccines are available today. One is a mix of purified capsular polysaccharides from multiple serotypes. Pneumovax 23 is an example. It does not work well in infants and offers short-lived protection.

To help boost the effects as well as the durability of the immune response, scientists have linked the polysaccharides to a carrier protein. Such vaccines are known as pneumococcal conjugate vaccines (PCVs). Typical examples include PCV10 and PCV14; the numerals denote the number of serotypes included.

When these vaccines target and eliminate some serotypes of *S. pneumoniae*, it also opens the door for other serotypes to mount an infection. These non-vaccine serotypes also face less biological competition for space and resources, so they multiply and eventually replace the vaccine-targeted serotypes, rendering the vaccines obsolete.

Second, many non-vaccine serotypes either possess antibiotic resistance genes or can acquire them from their resistant counterparts. This leads to the rise of both vaccine- and antibiotic-resistant serotypes.

Thus, scientists are looking for a universal pneumococcal vaccine that can target all serotypes and prevent these outcomes, which keep the threat of pneumonia, meningitis, and other pneumococcal diseases alive in the population.



The agar plate with red blood cells on the left shows a positive Staphylococcus infection and on the right shows a positive Streptococcus infection. NCI/UNSPASH

Reverse vaccinology starts from the germ's genome to identify proteins that can be included in vaccines. Scientists demonstrated an example of this in the recent COVID-19 pandemic: once the virus's genome was sequenced in early 2020, scientists around the world could analyse it and zero in on the spike-protein gene to make COVID-19 vaccines. The approach completely bypassed the need to culture the germs in large bioreactors and purify molecular components from them to make the vaccine.

The *S. pneumoniae* genome encodes more than 2,000 genes. Of them, around 1,300 are common across serotypes. The genomic data of more than 20,000 *S. pneumoniae* isolates across nearly a hundred serotypes are also available in the public domain.

The scientists deployed extensive computational analysis using an arsenal of bioinformatic tools to analyse these sequences.

They reasoned that the best candidate genes for creating their universal vaccine would need to encode for proteins with three attributes: (i) it must be located on the surface so that the immune system can easily access it; (ii) it must have low or no similarity to human proteins, so that the immune system does not attack the body's tissue, and (iii) it must be capable of eliciting a robust and durable anti-pneumococcal immunity.

The team shortlisted some candidates and further whittled the list down based on their predicted shapes and stability. From this, the team picked three

candidate genes. They were: zinc metalloprotease B (Z), pneumococcal adherence virulence factor A (P), and a protein which the scientists designated YfhO-like (Y) due to its similarity to another bacterial protein.

The team produced proteins Z, P, and Y in the laboratory and made an experimental vaccine by mixing them together. They also added two non-protein immune response boosters: a small piece of synthetic DNA called CpG and a sugary polymer called chitosan. They named this formulation ZPY-CpG-Ch.

Potent antibodies

To test whether the vaccine could elicit protective anti-pneumococcal antibodies, the scientists vaccinated laboratory mice. After some time, they exposed the mice to a lethal dose of *S. pneumoniae* serotype 1, which is known to be hypervirulent. Compared to unvaccinated mice, all of which succumbed to the lethal dose, vaccinated mice showed 80-100% survival.

Importantly, the scientists found that the level of protection offered by ZPY-CpG-Ch was comparable to that of PCV13.

The team also found that antibodies from the mice vaccinated with ZPY-CpG-Ch could help kill *S. pneumoniae* bacteria in a test tube. When injected into unvaccinated mice, the antibodies could also protect them against a lethal dose of serotype 1.

Third, ZPY-CpG-Ch fully protected

vaccinated mice exposed to lethal doses of two non-vaccine serotypes, 11A and 33F. It also offered 50% protection against a third non-vaccine serotype, called serotype 8.

In all mouse experiments, measures of the vaccine's protective effect based on the bacterial load in lungs and blood mirrored the rodents' survival rates. However, the ZPY-CpG-Ch vaccine did not reduce the load of pneumococcal bacteria in the upper respiratory passages of vaccinated mice. That is, despite being protected, vaccinated mice have the ability to still spread the infection to uninfected mice.

Worthy goal

Finally, the team also reported that vaccinating mice with ZPY-CpG-Ch stimulated a subset of immune cells that are implicated in pneumococcal immunity.

The results from this work are too preliminary for ZPY-CpG-Ch to be a universal pneumococcal vaccine. It has also been tested against a very small subset of serotypes, four to be precise. Vaccine data from laboratory mice also may not truly reflect the human situation.

Nevertheless, this work represents a baby step towards the worthy goal of developing a universal pneumococcal vaccine.

(S. Swaminathan is a retired professor of biology at BITS-Pilani, Hyderabad, and a former scientist at ICGEB, New Delhi. ssn225@gmail.com)



Scientist Akiko Takii collects samples from a young Asiatic black bear before releasing it back into the wild in Nagano, Japan, in July 2026. AFP

An alternative emerges to check Japan's bear troubles

Agence France-Presse

As a sensor sounded, scientist Akiko Takii hurried to a bear trap deep in the forests of Nagano in Japan, where rising attacks have brought fear and resulted in the culling of thousands of the animals. "It is a small bear, I think, about a year and a half old," Ms. Takii said as she peered at the 15-kilogramme Asiatic black bear thrashing in the cage. "It must have just parted from mum." Its mother was not around, and Ms. Takii took blood and fur samples after her co-researcher tranquilised the young female. The animal was too small to be tagged with a GPS tracker, so she was released.

The process of trapping, tagging, and releasing the animals is part of a pioneering management plan launched in 1995, as authorities realised the bear population was shrinking in the mountainous region in the centre of Japan's Honshu island. And it is becoming part of a model of coexistence in the region that some experts believe is an alternative to the dominant practice of culling the animals in an effort to prevent attacks. "By not killing too many of them, more bears survive to live out their expected lifespan. In that sense, a healthy bear population is being formed," Ms. Takii said of the process, which is paired with other methods intended to keep bears away from humans and monitor their movement.

Even before a cull guidance in Japan was expanded in April, large numbers of bears were being killed; however, several communities are embracing co-existence to prevent attacks

Another group in the area used specially trained Karelian Bear Dogs to scare bears away, and more than 3,000 kilometres of fencing was installed near farms, towns, and along rivers to prevent encounters. Bears who slip through are tranquilised, tagged, and set free far away. The programme has been credited with prompting both a recovery in bear numbers – although the animals are hard to count – and fewer encounters with humans.

There is little sympathy across much of Japan for healthy bear populations. Bears have killed six people nationwide since April 1, after a record 13 fatal attacks last fiscal year, according to the Environment Ministry. Sightings last year doubled the previous record and bears are increasingly entering the outskirts of towns and cities.

The causes are complex and, including variations in the availability of food like acorns, are potentially linked to climate change. The emptying out of rural areas due to depopulation and urbanisation is also leaving forests, farmland, and buffer zones less managed, said Shuichi Kitoh, a Tokyo University professor emeritus of environmental ethics. The government's response has focused largely on culling bears, expanding the process beyond animals in towns to those that wander into buffer zones on the outskirts. Even before the cull guidance was expanded in April, large numbers of bears were being killed – a record 14,000 last fiscal year, or almost 40 a day.

Ms. Takii argued Nagano's coexistence programme offered a different path.

While direct comparisons are difficult, some figures appear to show it has helped limit dangerous encounters. Annual sightings have remained broadly stable at around 1,400 in recent years, while some northern prefectures have recorded sharp increases. Last year, Nagano recorded 11 bear-related incidents, including one death, compared with 59 encounters and four deaths in Akita further north and five fatalities in Iwate.

THE SCIENCE QUIZ

It works — but we do not know how

Vasudevan Mukunth

QUESTION 1

The element X is one of the most effective mood stabilisers known, but after having been in use for decades, medical researchers still lack consensus about how exactly it works. Leading theories say it affects inositol signalling and inhibits the GSK-3 enzyme, but they haven't been able to explain all of X's effects. Name X.

QUESTION 2

The general form of _____ induce unconsciousness, amnesia, and immobility during surgery and have been used safely for over 150 years, yet scientists still lack a cohesive theory of how they work at the molecular level. Different forms of the drugs also seem to act through somewhat different molecular routes, yet succeed in inducing unconsciousness. Fill in the blank.

QUESTION 3

The BCS theory does a good job

of explaining conventional superconductivity. However, high-temperature superconductors that scientists found in compounds called Y in the 1980s still lack a complete and cogent theoretical explanation for how they superconduct. Name Y.

QUESTION #4

_____, a.k.a. Glucophage, is used worldwide as a first-line drug in the treatment of type II diabetes, yet scientists are still figuring out how it lowers blood glucose levels. Some leading ideas include the drug's effects on the gut microbiome and the mitochondrial complex I. Fill in the blank.

QUESTION #5

At sub-anesthetic doses, name the drug derived from phencyclidine — and which was used as surgical anesthesia during the Vietnam War — that can lift severe depression within hours, in dramatic contrast to the drugs called SSRIs. As with other therapies on this list, its full mechanism of action is still unclear.



Visual: Name the phenomenon depicted here as an aeroplane flies through coloured smoke. A complete analytical theory describing it is one of the Millennium Prize problems. NASA

Answers to August 27 quiz:

1. Businessman who drilled world's first commercial oil well – Ans: **Edwin Drake**
 2. Substance yielded along with crude oil, used to be flared off – Ans: **Natural gas**
 3. Components of hydraulic fracturing fluid – Ans: **Water and sand**
 4. Valve systems that prevented uncontrolled gushing of oil – Ans: **Blowout preventers**
 5. Machines called 'nodding donkeys' to mechanically lift oil – Ans: **Pump jacks**
- Visual: **Paul Thomas Anderson directed There Will Be Blood**

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For feedback and suggestions

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Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Amount mobilised by banks in deposits from Indian diaspora

127.23 in \$ billion. India attracted a whopping USD 127.23 billion in Foreign Currency Non-Resident (FCNR-B) deposits under the Reserve Bank's special USD-INR forex swap facility till August 31, the closing date. The RBI's special USD-INR forex swap facility was launched on June 8, 2026. PTI

Length of Manipur's border with Myanmar that has been fenced

55 in kilometres. Manipur Home Minister Govindas Konhoujam on Wednesday said that nearly 55 km out of 398 km of the State's international border with Myanmar has been fenced. Mr. Konhoujam was responding to a calling attention motion raised by Congress MLA K. Ranjit Singh on the "reported proposal for a land swap deal between India and Myanmar". PTI

Number of dengue cases recorded in Delhi till August 29

311 As many as 311 cases of dengue, 119 of malaria and 22 of chikungunya have been recorded in Delhi till August 29 this year, while no death has been reported due to any of the diseases. Delhi recorded its highest monthly tally of dengue cases this year in August, with 90 infections reported during the month, a Municipal Corporation of Delhi report says. PTI

Number of special trains operated during Onam season this year

180 As many as 180 special train services were operated in the Thiruvananthapuram Division during the Onam festive season this year, carrying an additional 2,45,823 passengers, railway officials said here on Wednesday. The division recorded an overall punctuality of 94.67% in August this year, compared to 91% during the same month last year. PTI

Applications received for police recruitment in Himachal Pradesh

98 in thousands. The State Public Service Commission has received over 98,000 applications for police constable recruitment till September 1, 2026, Himachal Pradesh CM Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu told the Assembly on Wednesday. He said the September 5 deadline for application would not be extended. PTI

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Constitutional faultlines in FCRA Bill

The FCRA Amendment Bill, 2026 provides for a 'Designated Authority' to oversee the management and disposal of foreign contributions and assets when an organisation's FCRA certificate is cancelled or ceases to exist; raising questions about the extent of State intervention and the need for sufficient safeguards against overreach

LETTER & SPIRIT

Thajaswini C.B.
Siddharth Dev Prasad

It is hard to deny that the state has a legitimate concern in regulating foreign contributions in India, as foreign donations raise issues concerning national security, transparency in democracy, and public accountability. For decades, the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act has been the instrument through which this interest has been pursued. However, the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026 raises a different question altogether. It goes beyond regulating foreign contributions, to the extent to which the state may intervene in assets and institutional activities associated with them.

The fundamental issue, therefore, is not a debate between civil society and national security. It is about where the State, in pursuit of its legitimate regulatory goal, may cross the boundary from regulating foreign contributions to exercising undue executive control over the institutions that receive them.

The Bill's most important aspect is a statutory framework for the vesting, supervision, management and disposal of foreign contributions and assets through a 'Designated Authority'. Where an organisation's FCRA certificate is cancelled, surrendered or ceases to exist, including due to non-renewal, the Central government may appoint an authority to which the foreign contribution and assets created from it may vest provisionally. The measure is framed as an accountability mechanism to prevent the diversion or abuse of such properties.

Expansion of statutory consequences However, the constitutional difficulty lies elsewhere.

The FCRA has always empowered the state to scrutinise foreign funding. If there are any violations in this regard, registrations can be withdrawn,



Opposition MPs protest in New Delhi on April 1, demanding the withdrawal of the FCRA Amendment Bill.

cancellation can follow continuing non-compliance, and penalties can attach to the diversion or misappropriation of foreign contributions. The Bill, however, represents a significant expansion of the statutory consequences that can follow the loss of FCRA registration. Importantly, the existing FCRA law already contains a provision for vesting assets created from foreign funds upon cancellation. What is new is the detailed statutory framework for their provisional vesting, possession, management, restoration and ultimately, permanent vesting and disposal.

In case of cancellation, surrender, or cessation of registration, the government may, through the Designated Authority, take possession of and manage assets created from foreign contributions and, where considered necessary or expedient in the public interest, undertake the management of the concerned organisation's activities. This is not merely a change in administrative policy; it raises a constitutional question about the extent to which a statute regulating foreign contributions may permit executive authorities to assume possession and, in specified circumstances, management of institutional assets and activities.

Even if the dichotomy between ownership and custody may have some legal relevance, its practical consequences are not. An entity whose success is dependent on the continuity of management will place greater emphasis on control than ownership. Ownership may remain formally undisturbed, but a change in management control fundamentally alters the relationship between the institution and the state. A hospital, school or laboratory is not made effective by ownership alone; it depends on its independence to administer, for charitable ends, what it owns.

Evaluation of proportionality

This is where the doctrine of constitutional proportionality may be relevant. The Supreme Court has repeatedly held that even where the state pursues a legitimate objective, the means it adopts must bear a reasonable connection to that objective and must maintain an appropriate balance between the public purpose and the burden imposed on rights. The amendment raises difficult questions when measured against the said rationale. If the consequence of losing FCRA registration is the provisional vesting of assets in, and potentially the

management of institutional activities by a government-appointed authority, the safeguards attending that transfer must be commensurately robust.

Therefore, the Bill warrants scrutiny of the extent of the discretion delegated to the executive, the safeguards governing its exercise and the standards applicable to decisions concerning possession, management, and permanent vesting. The Bill provides for the restoration of assets when registration is obtained, renewed, or restored within the prescribed period, as well as mechanisms for revision and judicial appeal. The constitutional question is whether these safeguards are sufficiently clear, timely and effective.

This concern becomes more significant against the broader regulatory landscape. Over the past decade, thousands of FCRA registrations have ceased to operate for reasons ranging from non-renewal to alleged statutory violations. While many regulatory actions may be justified, the Bill may increase the consequences arising from the cessation of registration. What might previously have been limited to the loss of eligibility to receive foreign funds could, under the proposed framework, extend to provisional management and, if registration is not restored within the prescribed period, permanent vesting and disposal of assets.

None of this suggests that the government lacks the authority to strengthen financial oversight or ensure that funds from abroad are used for lawful and proper ends. But in a constitutional order, any regime that reaches into the management of civil society's institutional infrastructure must operate within clear legislative standards.

Ultimately, the constitutional question posed by the FCRA Amendment Bill is not whether foreign contributions should be regulated, but how far the state may go in regulating institutions and their assets. (Thajaswini C.B. is an advocate practising before the Supreme Court, Madras and Delhi High Courts. Siddharth Dev Prasad is a 4th year law student at Gujarat National Law University.)

THE GIST

The FCRA has always empowered the state to scrutinise foreign funding. The amendment Bill, however, represents a significant expansion of the statutory consequences that can follow the loss of FCRA registration.

Therefore, the Bill warrants scrutiny of the extent of the discretion delegated to the executive, the safeguards governing its exercise and the standards applicable to decisions concerning possession, management, and permanent vesting.

Can jurists be appointed as Supreme Court judges?

Why has the provision allowing distinguished jurists to be appointed as SC judges remained unused?

Aaratrika Bhaumik

The story so far:

Supreme Court judge Justice Ujjal Bhuyan on Sunday questioned why a constitutional provision allowing a "distinguished jurist" to be appointed as a judge of the Supreme Court has remained unused for more than 76 years. Addressing the 13th convocation of National Law University, Delhi's LL.M. programme, Justice Bhuyan pointed out that Article 124(3) of the Constitution permits the appointment of a person who, in the President's opinion, is a "distinguished jurist" as a Supreme Court judge. However, no legal academic has so far been elevated to the top court under this provision.

What does the Constitution stipulate?

Article 124(3) of the Constitution lays down three routes through which a

person may qualify for appointment as a Supreme Court judge – a person must have served as a High Court judge for at least five years, practised as an advocate of a High Court for at least 10 years, or be, in the opinion of the President, a "distinguished jurist".

The provision, however, does not define who qualifies as a "distinguished jurist" or prescribe any minimum period of professional experience for such a person. Its inclusion as a separate category nevertheless indicates that the framers contemplated a route to the Supreme Court beyond the conventional pathways of judicial service and legal practice, potentially opening the door to eminent legal scholars and academics.

What do Constituent Assembly debates reflect?

The "distinguished jurist" category was added to the list of persons eligible for

appointment to the Supreme Court in the draft Constitution. The Constituent Assembly debates reflect that this was intended to bring diversity in professional backgrounds among those appointed to the Bench of the Supreme Court.

Moving the amendment on May 24, 1949, Constituent Assembly member H.V. Kamath said it sought "to open a wider field of choice" for Supreme Court appointments. He noted that persons with "outstanding legal and juristic learning" were "not necessarily confined to judges or advocates", pointing to the selection of judges of the International Court of Justice on similar terms.

The Constituent Assembly debates also referred to the appointment of Felix Frankfurter to the U.S. Supreme Court. In 1939, President Franklin D. Roosevelt appointed Frankfurter, who had been a professor at Harvard Law School for 25 years, as an Associate Justice of the U.S.

Supreme Court. Justice Frankfurter went on to become a noted advocate of the doctrine of judicial restraint – the principle that courts should respect the domain of the elected legislature and the executive, and exercise restraint in interfering with their decisions.

Assembly member M. Ananthasayanam Ayyangar cited Justice Frankfurter's appointment as a "novel experiment" that had worked well, noting that legal expertise was not confined to practising lawyers or judges.

Can a 'distinguished jurist' be appointed as a High Court judge?

The Constituent Assembly had also considered allowing "distinguished jurists" to be appointed as High Court judges. On June 7, 1949, Professor Shibban Lal Saksena moved an amendment proposing their inclusion among those eligible for appointment to a High Court. The proposal, however, was not accepted.

Nearly three decades later, the Constitution (Forty-second Amendment) Act, 1976, enacted during the Emergency, amended Article 217, which lays down the qualifications for appointment as a High Court judge. The amendment allowed a person who was, in the opinion of the President, a "distinguished jurist" to be appointed to a High Court. The provision came into force in January 1977 but was omitted by the Constitution (Forty-fourth

Amendment) Act, 1978.

What limits the use of this provision?

Despite being part of the Constitution since its inception, the provision has never been invoked. Supreme Court judges have overwhelmingly been appointed from among High Court judges, with only 11 advocates directly elevated from the Bar.

The appointment process itself may also help explain why the provision has remained unused, since a jurist would first have to be recommended by the Supreme Court Collegium. Legal scholar Upendra Baxi, whose possible appointment to the court never materialised, described the provision as a "dead issue" in a 2015 interview with LiveLaw.

Another concern is that legal academics may lack courtroom and procedural experience. However, full-time law teachers themselves face restrictions on practising as advocates. Under Rule 49 of the Bar Council of India Rules, an advocate who takes up full-time salaried employment must cease to practise while such employment continues. In 2019, the Consortium of National Law Universities sought a relaxation of this restriction to allow full-time faculty to practise in courts and bridge the divide between "law in books" and "law in action".

